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Live Streaming Shopping as an Activation Mechanism in the Omnichannel Customer Journey

A Qualitative Study of Consumer and Retailer Perspectives

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Abstract

This thesis examines the role of live streaming shopping (LSS) within the omnichannel customer journey, focusing on whether and under which conditions a livestream encourages consumers to continue their journey in a physical store. While existing research has largely treated LSS as a self-contained digital sales channel, its interaction with physical retail has received comparatively little attention. Adopting an exploratory, interpretivist design, the study draws on two consumer focus groups (nine participants) and one semi-structured expert interview with a Brand & Digital Retail Manager at a mid-sized European fashion retailer. The material was analyzed through hybrid deductive-inductive thematic analysis following Braun and Clarke (2006). The findings suggest that participants did not frame their decisions as a choice between channels but as a question of whether they had obtained sufficient information. Cognitive uncertainty was frequently resolved within the stream, whereas sensory uncertainty concerning fit, texture or firmness typically was not. In the two cases in which a store visit followed a livestream, participants described it as a targeted continuation of an ongoing decision process rather than as a failure of the digital channel. Trust emerged not only as an outcome of repeated exposure but also as a facilitating mechanism, strengthened in particular where hosts openly acknowledged what the format could not convey. On this basis the thesis develops an exploratory Conditional Activation Model that specifies cognitive resolution, residual sensory uncertainty, host credibility and a set of contextual factors as interacting conditions of offline continuation. Given the small sample and the limited number of reported transitions, the model is offered as a framework for further research rather than as a validated account. The study contributes to omnichannel retailing research by repositioning LSS as a conditional activation mechanism and offers retailers guidance on differentiating livestream objectives by product category.

Keywords: live streaming shopping; omnichannel customer journey; webrooming; ROPO; uncertainty reduction; parasocial interaction; host credibility; channel complementarity; qualitative research; thematic analysis

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1 Introduction

Over the past decade, live streaming shopping (LSS) has developed into one of the most significant innovations in digital retail. By combining real-time video broadcasting, interactive communication between hosts and viewers, and integrated purchasing functions, LSS has evolved from a niche phenomenon into a multi-billion-dollar industry (Tian et al., 2026, p. 1). While the format has become firmly established in Chinese e-commerce, it is also gaining increasing attention among retailers in Europe and other Western markets (Tian et al., 2026, p. 1). For many brands, LSS is no longer viewed simply as an additional sales channel but as a way of combining entertainment, social interaction, and commerce in a manner that traditional e-commerce platforms cannot easily replicate (Wongkitrungrueng & Assarut, 2020, p. 543).

Although interest in LSS has grown considerably, existing research has largely examined the format as a digital sales channel in its own right. Most studies focus on why consumers participate in livestreams, which psychological mechanisms drive engagement and purchase intentions, or how characteristics of the host and the livestream influence purchasing decisions within the stream itself (Xu et al., 2025, p. 1). While this research has generated valuable insights into the internal dynamics of LSS, comparatively little attention has been paid to its role within the broader customer journey. Although Picot-Coupey et al. (2023) provide a first structured overview positioning LSS as a touchpoint within the omnichannel continuum, they explicitly identify the interdependencies between LSS and physical stores, as well as questions of channel integration and cannibalization, as central open research questions (Picot-Coupey et al., 2023). In particular, there is still limited understanding of whether and how LSS influences consumer behavior beyond the digital environment, including visits to physical retail stores. This gap is relevant from both a theoretical and a practical perspective. The omnichannel retailing literature has consistently shown that consumers move flexibly between online and offline channels throughout their purchase journey, often researching products in one channel before completing the purchase in another (Verhoef et al., 2007, p. 129; 2015, pp. 174-176). Concepts such as the Research Online, Purchase Offline (ROPO) effect and webrooming illustrate that purchasing decisions are rarely confined to a single channel. To better understand the role of LSS within this broader omnichannel context, it is therefore necessary to examine whether livestreams influence behavior beyond immediate online purchases rather than evaluating them solely as standalone digital sales events.

From a managerial perspective, this question is equally important. Retailers operating both digital and physical channels face increasing uncertainty regarding the strategic role of LSS within their overall retail ecosystem. While livestreams are often evaluated according to their ability to generate immediate online sales, they may also create value by strengthening brand familiarity, reducing purchase uncertainty, and encouraging consumers to continue their shopping journey in physical stores. Understanding these cross-channel effects is therefore essential for retailers seeking to integrate LSS effectively into an omnichannel strategy.

Against this background, the present study investigates the role of live streaming shopping in activating the omnichannel customer journey, with particular attention to its influence on physical store visits and purchases. Rather than viewing LSS solely as an isolated digital sales channel, this thesis conceptualizes it as a potential catalyst that shapes consumer behavior across multiple touchpoints. More specifically, it seeks to explain not only whether LSS encourages offline behavior, but also under which conditions this transition occurs and which underlying mechanisms drive it.

To address this objective, the study is guided by the following research questions:

RQ1: Under what conditions does a live streaming shopping session encourage consumers to visit a physical store?

RQ2: How do trust, brand familiarity, and residual uncertainty interact in motivating offline continuation?

RQ3: Under what circumstances does live streaming shopping function as a complement to physical retail, and under what circumstances does it instead substitute for the in-store experience?

To answer these questions, the study adopts a qualitative, interpretivist research approach. Data were collected through two consumer focus groups and one semi-structured expert interview with a Brand & Digital Retail Manager at a mid-sized fashion retailer. Combining these perspectives makes it possible to examine both how consumers experience the transition from livestream shopping to offline behavior and how retailers perceive and manage this relationship in practice.

The remainder of this thesis is organized as follows. Chapter 2 develops the theoretical foundation by reviewing the literature on live streaming shopping, omnichannel retailing, and consumer behavior across channels. Based on this review, a conceptual framework and the research questions are developed. Chapter 3 explains the methodological approach, including the research design, data collection, and thematic analysis. Chapter 4 presents the empirical findings, organized around the three research questions. These findings are discussed in relation to the existing literature in Chapter 5, before Chapter 6 develops an integrated interpretation of the results and proposes a Conditional Activation Model explaining how LSS may encourage offline consumer behavior. Building on these findings, Chapter 7 derives practical recommendations for retailers, Chapter 8 reflects on the study's limitations, and Chapter 9 concludes the thesis by summarizing its theoretical and practical contributions while outlining directions for future research.

2 Literature Review

2.1 Live Streaming Shopping

2.1.1 Definition and Key Characteristics

Live Streaming Shopping is a commerce format in which the host presents products to an online live audience. This happens exclusively online, enabling users to ask questions, interact, and purchase without leaving the online platform (Picot-Coupey et al., 2023; Wongkitrungrueng & Assarut, 2020, p. 543). While normal e-commerce websites mostly focus on the product presentation by displaying pictures, LSS enables consumers to see and evaluate the usage and different perspectives of products. This hybrid experience allows sellers to integrate entertaining activities, blurring the boundaries between commerce, social interaction and entertainment, in order to encourage the consumer to buy instantly (Wongkitrungrueng & Assarut, 2020, p. 543).

One of the first online platforms integrating live streaming was Twitch, where people did not only participate for the gaming aspect, but especially for the social and community building part. Participants are able to watch streamers play videogames while also communicating with them and other members through the chat. These same dynamics of community engagement and real-time interaction are now characteristic of today’s LSS (Hamilton et al., 2014, pp. 1315-1316).

The live streaming commerce sector has undergone significant growth in recent years. Two distinct indicators illustrate this development and should not be conflated. The first concerns the market for live commerce platforms themselves, that is, the technological and service infrastructure enabling the format. This platform market reached USD 12.8

billion in 2024 and is projected to grow at a compound annual rate of 18.2 percent, reaching USD 54.6 billion by 2033 (Tian et al., 2026, p. 1). The second indicator concerns transaction volume, which is of a considerably larger order of magnitude. In China, which continues to drive global growth, live streaming transactions amounted to 4.92 trillion yuan in 2023, an increase of 40.48 percent over the previous year, with 597 million users participating in the format (Tian et al., 2026, p. 1). By May 2025, 72 percent of new customers in the Chinese market were reported to be acquired through live streaming channels. As the sector transitions from a phase of rapid user acquisition to one of consolidation, the central competitive challenge for platforms and brands has become the retention of existing customers (Tian et al., 2026, pp. 1-2). While live streaming is already deeply embedded in the Chinese market, where broadcasters can even receive professional training, other countries are still in the early adoption phase, where live streamers work on their own without proper training (Lu & Chen, 2021, p. 2). Live Streaming Shopping differs from other digital retail formats as it can target customers differently, encouraging purchases. Three main characteristics support the rapid growth of LSS. The first is uncertainty reduction. Uncertainty about how a product will fit or look is one of the main purchasing constraints for consumers (Lu & Chen, 2021, p. 1; Sun et al., 2026, p. 3). Broadcasters address this constraint by showing the product from different perspectives, trying it on themselves, or answering questions directly (Dong et al., 2025, p. 1; Wongkitrungrueng & Assarut, 2020, pp. 545-546). Second, LSS operates in real time, creating a sense of urgency and temporal scarcity that consumers do not experience to the same extent on conventional e-commerce platforms. Because offers are known to be time-limited, consumers feel pressured to decide more quickly (Dong et al., 2025, p. 2). Third, LSS is hosted by a human being, who may be an ordinary seller, a brand representative, an influencer or even a celebrity (Park & Lin, 2020, p. 1). Their personal presence is significant for trust building. Once trust is built, consumers will think the broadcaster will recommend the right products with good quality for them and tend to purchase (Lu & Chen, 2021, p. 1).

Taken together, these three characteristics distinguish LSS fundamentally from conventional e-commerce platforms.

2.1.2 Key Psychological Mechanisms of LSS

Live Streaming Shopping has a psychological impact on consumer behavior which can be explained through the Stimulus-Organism-Response (S-O-R) framework (Mehrabian

& Russell, 1974), which has been widely applied in the LSS context (Widjaja et al., 2026, p. 2). In this case, as discussed above, LSS provides features such as temporal scarcity, human hosts and uncertainty reduction, which correspond to the Stimuli (S). These activate the internal cognitive and emotional state of the consumer (O), triggering behavioral responses (R) such as purchase intention and engagement (Widjaja et al., 2026, p. 2).

One of the key stimuli in LSS is interactivity. As explained before, LSS is a real-time system where host and customer can interact with one another, answering questions and reducing doubts. This contrasts with the conventional e-commerce system, in which information does not flow in both directions but only towards the customer (Wongkitrungrueng & Assarut, 2020, pp. 545-546). With LSS, this interactive dynamic reduces the psychological barrier separating the customer and the seller (Widjaja et al., 2026, p. 5) and creating a sense of personal connection (Sun et al., 2026, p. 5) that closely matches the social interaction found in a retail store (Wongkitrungrueng & Assarut, 2020, p. 552). Another key psychological mechanism in LSS that builds on interactivity is parasocial interaction. Horton and Wohl (1956, p. 215) describe this mechanism as a one-sided emotional bond that viewers form with a media personality. In LSS the repeated interaction of viewers with a live streamer can create a sense of intimacy and close connection, resulting in customers considering the host as a trusted acquaintance (Wongkitrungrueng & Assarut, 2020, p. 545). This not only creates more trust but also sustains long-term engagement. Widjaja et al. (2026, p. 10) found that streamer- and telepresence interactions build customer trust, whereas conventional platform interactions have no significant effect.

Interactivity and parasocial interaction may also contribute to a state of flow, understood as deep cognitive absorption characterized by focused attention, altered time perception, and intrinsic enjoyment (Csikszentmihalyi, 1990). Hoffman and Novak (1996) introduced this construct into research on computer-mediated environments, arguing that flow increases exploratory behavior and the time consumers spend within a given environment. Applied to LSS, this suggests that consumers in a state of flow may be more responsive to the purchase cues presented during a stream, although the present study does not test this relationship directly. In addition to the immediate experience of the stream, consumers may subsequently recognize that they have been in a state of flow consciousness, a phenomenon shown to influence post-purchase emotions and future engagement across channels (Yuan et al., 2026, p. 802).

The psychological effects of LSS result from a complex interplay between interactivity, parasocial interaction and flow. Of these mechanisms, interactivity and parasocial interaction are the most directly relevant to the present study, since both shape whether consumers accept the information provided during a stream as reliable, and they therefore feed into the analysis of trust and credibility in Chapters 4 and 6. Flow is introduced here for completeness. It emerged in the focus groups as a feature of the viewing experience, but it did not bear directly on the transition from livestream to physical store and is consequently reported as a supplementary finding rather than integrated into the framework developed in Section 6.4. This study posits that the first two effects in particular may extend beyond the stream into other channels, including the physical store.

2.1.3 Consumer Value Dimensions in LSS

In order to understand why consumers participate in LSS in the first place, it is necessary to examine the value they expect to derive from the experience. Babin et al. (1994, pp. 644-645) demonstrated that there exist two distinct shopping value dimensions, hedonic and utilitarian, which are related to a number of important consumption variables. Elaborating on this framework, Wongkitrungrueng and Assarut (2020, p. 544) added a third dimension, symbolic value. Through this extension they demonstrate how consumer engagement and trust with live streaming sellers is shaped.

Utilitarian value is defined by the functional and informational benefits of a stream. This could be in the form of real-time questions and answers, price comparisons or product demonstration. In the context of LSS, utilitarian value is most closely linked to consumers' trust in a product. Consumers who find a stream to be informative and authentic develop greater trust in its quality and suitability (Wongkitrungrueng & Assarut, 2020, p. 551). This is especially important in the apparel and cosmetics sector, where product uncertainty is usually higher (Lu & Chen, 2021, p. 1). Studies comparing online product presentation tools show that LSS and augmented reality (AR) are equally effective at reducing product uncertainty for products with low experiential value. However, AR is more effective for products with high experiential value (Sun et al., 2026, p. 12). These results suggest that LSS's ability to reduce uncertainty is limited, particularly for products that require in-depth sensory evaluation.

Customers also desire a hedonic value. This term refers to the recreational, emotional, and experiential advantages of shopping. In the LSS context this refers to a charismatic host, real-time interaction, and a shared viewing community that turns the shopping experience into an entertaining activity (Wongkitrungrueng & Assarut, 2020, p. 546). Hedonic value indirectly influences trust in the product, thereby promoting consumer engagement through an affective channel. As discussed in the preceding section, the flow state represents the highest level of hedonic value. In this state, consumers become so engaged that their spontaneous purchasing behavior is significantly increased (Widjaja et al., 2026, p. 4).

LSS has been shown to create functional and experiential benefits, while also generating symbolic value (Wongkitrungrueng & Assarut, 2020, p. 546). This symbolic value operates on two levels: the individual and group level. At the individual level, customers typically identify with the appearance, values, and lifestyle of the host (Hu et al., 2017, p. 596). At the group level, it is more about social identification with other participants, enabling a sense of belonging (Badrinarayanan et al., 2015, p. 1047).

Importantly, the three value dimensions do not contribute equally to consumer engagement. Research shows that symbolic value has the strongest direct effect on engagement. In contrast, utilitarian and hedonic values only influence engagement through the mediation of trust in products and, later, trust in sellers (Wongkitrungrueng & Assarut, 2020, p. 551).

A growing number of studies in the field of LSS show that consumer decision-making mainly relies on value considerations. Streamer appeal, price appeal, design appeal, and social interaction are the main factors affecting shopping value, which then influences purchase intention (Xu et al., 2025, p. 4). This finding matches observations from related digital formats. In fashion vlogging, certain qualities of vloggers, like attractiveness, expertise, and trustworthiness, significantly impact product attitude and purchase intention. The emotional connection between the viewer and creator acts as a moderating factor in these effects (Choi & Lee, 2019, p. 6).

For the present study, utilitarian value is the most theoretically relevant dimension. When consumers are unable to fully evaluate a product through online channels, particularly for high-touch products like apparel or cosmetics, residual uncertainty may motivate a subsequent store visit (Hwang & Youn, 2023, p. 7). This dynamic represents a direct pathway through which LSS-generated value may activate offline consumer behavior, a central argument of this thesis.

Figure 1 shows a screenshot from a live-streaming session by L'Oréal Paris, in which the host demonstrates skincare products to the viewers.

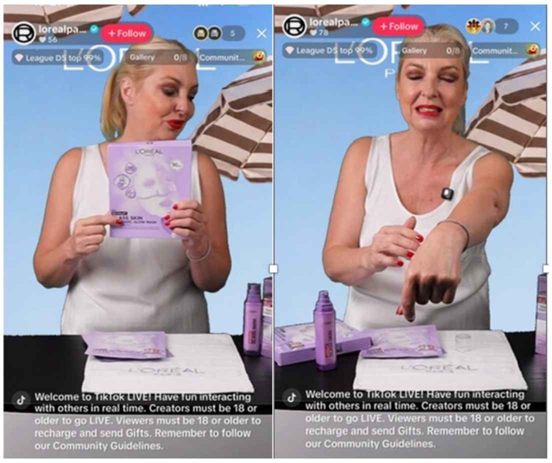

Figure 1: L'Oréal Paris live streaming session on TikTok, demonstrating real-time product application (utilitarian value), host-viewer interaction (hedonic value), and brand identity communication (symbolic value). Source: Own screenshot, 16.06.2026.

As shown in Figure 1, the host addresses all three value dimensions in one interaction. She provides product information with a real-time demonstration. She creates an engaging and sensory experience for the viewer. She also uses the brand's identity to strengthen symbolic associations. However, it is important to point out that the physical texture of the cream, which is a key factor for many consumers, can only be suggested through the screen. This might drive consumers to visit a store to evaluate their purchase. While a growing number of studies have been conducted on LSS, most of the available research still perceives LSS as an individual channel, focusing solely on its conversion rate and purchase intention to determine its success. How LSS works with other channels, and whether it triggers any offline consumer activity, remains unknown. This is precisely what the current research aims to address, viewing LSS as a touchpoint in the omnichannel customer journey, which will be described below.

2.2 The Omnichannel Customer Journey

2.2.1 From Multichannel to Omnichannel

The way consumers interact with retailers has changed significantly over the last two decades due to the rise of digital channels such as online stores, mobile apps, and social media sites. As a result, the boundaries among different shopping venues have been gradually blurred. Therefore, retailers must reevaluate their approach to managing consumer interactions (Verhoef et al., 2015, p. 174).

This evolution is evident in the shift towards omnichannel retailing, representing a progression from multichannel to cross-channel strategies. Multichannel retailing was the first strategy employed by retailers, whereby multichannel meant using several channels by the same firm, e.g., a physical store and website (Neslin et al., 2006, p. 96). Neslin et al. (2006, p. 96) define multichannel customer management as the design, deployment, coordination, and evaluation of channels through which firms and customers interact, with the goal of enhancing customer value through effective customer acquisition, retention, and development. In this initial stage, channels were typically managed separately and with minimal coordination between them. As a result, customers experienced fragmented shopping journeys: product availability on websites did not necessarily match in-store inventory, and prices and promotional offers varied significantly across channels (Verhoef et al., 2015, p. 175; Gasparin et al., 2022, p. 2). Cross-channel retailing represents a subsequent stage of development. Firms began to recognize the interdependencies between their channels and enabled a certain degree of interaction between them, for example by allowing consumers to purchase online and return items in-store. However, the firm's perspective continued to dominate, meaning that integration remained primarily operational rather than customer-centric (Gasparin et al., 2022, p. 2).

Omnichannel retailing, however, is a more fundamentally different approach. Rather than treating channels as distinct units to be coordinated, the omnichannel approach focuses on how shoppers are influenced and move through channels when searching for and purchasing products (Verhoef et al., 2015, p. 174). This change is characterized by two simultaneous developments. Firstly, the range of relevant channels now includes all customer interactions, extending beyond traditional retail environments. Secondly, the distinctions between online and offline spaces are becoming less clear as consumers move freely between them (Gasparin et al., 2022, p. 2). In this sense, a channel is the medium through which the firm and the customer interact (Neslin et al., 2006, p. 96), while a touchpoint denotes an individual interaction between a customer and a firm along the customer journey (De Keyser et al., 2020, as cited in Gasparin et al., 2022). This distinction is important from a theoretical perspective. While the multichannel approach focuses on the channel, the omnichannel approach emphasizes the customer journey, a series of touchpoints that may encompass both digital and physical realms during a single decision-making process (Lemon & Verhoef, 2016, pp. 69-70). The omnichannel concept therefore represents a significant challenge to the "integration imperative" that has long guided managerial thinking. This concept is based on the understanding that maintaining consistency and ensuring seamless connectivity across all touchpoints contributes to a more positive customer experience (Gasparin et al., 2022, pp. 1-2). Gasparin et al. (2022, p. 2) demonstrate, based on qualitative data from Finnish and Brazilian consumers, that two distinct dimensions of journey integration, perceived consistency and perceived connectivity of touchpoints, interact in complex ways. Furthermore, they establish that low consistency or low connectivity do not necessarily translate into negative experiences.

These findings indicate that the relationship between channel integration and customer experience is more complex than is often assumed in the omnichannel literature. Rather than following universal recommendations for omnichannel strategy, they highlight the need to consider how consumers themselves perceive and navigate transitions between different channels and touchpoints. In the context of the present study, the omnichannel perspective serves as the theoretical framework for examining live streaming shopping. LSS is not viewed as an isolated digital shopping format, but as one element within a broader customer journey that may also involve physical store visits and offline purchases. The primary objective of this study is to examine how LSS is integrated into this process and to identify the conditions under which it promotes, rather than replaces, subsequent offline consumer behavior.

2.2.2 Touchpoints and Channel Integration

Lemon and Verhoef (2016, p. 74) define four categories of touchpoints, depending on the parties that control them: brand-owned touchpoints (e.g., websites, retail locations, and advertisements), partner-owned touchpoints (e.g., intermediaries and delivery services), customer-owned touchpoints (e.g., individual choices regarding consumption and post-purchase use), and social/external touchpoints (e.g., peer influences, independent review sites, and social media). The relative importance of each touchpoint category shifts depending on the stage of the customer journey, whether it is pre-purchase, purchase, or post-purchase (Lemon & Verhoef, 2016, p. 76). Research indicates that integrating online and offline channels does not result in customer loss, but rather generates positive synergies. Studies show that consumers exposed to integrated channels maintain their intention to visit and make purchases in physical stores. This supports the concept that digital and physical channels are complementary rather than competitive (Herhausen et al., 2015, p. 320). Gasparin et al. (2022, p. 2) recognize two key dimensions through which this integration can be evaluated from the customer's viewpoint. The first is perceived consistency. This can be described as the extent to which customers perceive coherence in retail mix elements, such as price, product information and assortment, across different customer touchpoints. Secondly, perceived connectivity refers to the extent to which customers can move seamlessly between different touchpoints during their purchase journey. While the omnichannel literature has traditionally viewed these two dimensions as interconnected or even interdependent, Gasparin et al. (2022, p. 5) show that they function as distinct and frequently independent attributes. Their findings reveal four distinct types of omnichannel journeys resulting from the relationship between these two dimensions. When both consistency and connectivity are high, consumers experience confidence and minimal cognitive effort. In cases where connectivity is strong but consistency is weak, consumers can still navigate the journey smoothly and may even have a positive experience. When there is a high level of consistency but a low level of connectivity, consumers may experience frustration and be unable to continue their journey. When both dimensions are low, this can lead to confusion and disengagement (Gasparin et al., 2022, p. 5). It is important to note that perceived connectivity has a greater impact on the overall customer experience than perceived consistency. This finding directly challenges firm-centric integration strategies that have traditionally dominated managerial practices (Gasparin et al., 2022, p. 9). The insights outlined above are particularly relevant to this study. According to the touchpoint typology proposed by Lemon and Verhoef (2016), live streaming shopping does not fit easily into a single category. A stream that is hosted by a brand functions as a touchpoint owned by that brand. In contrast, a stream conducted by an independent influencer or content creator can be considered a social or external touchpoint. However, regardless of the host, LSS is strategically positioned to serve as a touchpoint that drives connectivity, guiding consumers towards further brand interactions, whether online or in physical stores. The conditions under which this actually takes place are not yet fully understood, and this is a central focus of the present study.

2.2.3 The ROPO Effect

The increasing complexity of the omnichannel customer journey has led to a variety of cross-channel shopping behaviors, with the ROPO effect being a particularly relevant example. ROPO, an acronym for "Research Online, Purchase Offline," describes the tendency of consumers to gather product information through digital channels before completing their purchase in a physical store (Verhoef et al., 2007, p. 129). Although the term is relatively new, the underlying behavior was identified in earlier multichannel research as the "research-shopper phenomenon." (Verhoef et al., 2007, p. 129).

Verhoef et al. (2007, p. 129) identify three fundamental mechanisms that drive cross-channel behavior: consumers selecting channels depending on their functional advantages, the ease of switching between channels, and the reinforcing effect that positive experiences in one channel have on the attractiveness of another. Of these three, their empirical findings indicate that the combination of internet search followed by an in-store purchase represents the most common form of research shopping, driven by all three mechanisms simultaneously (Verhoef et al., 2007, p. 140). This insight is significant for omnichannel retail, as positive digital experiences foster what Verhoef et al. (2007, p. 129) describe as "cross-channel synergy," a dynamic where positive experiences in one channel motivate engagement in another.

Further research differentiated this consumer behavior into two contrary patterns: showrooming, where consumers search in a physical store before purchasing online, and webrooming, where consumers research online before purchasing in a store (Verhoef et al., 2015, p. 175). The term "webrooming" encompasses the broader concept of ROPO, which refers to the consumer preference to gather digital information before making purchases offline (Verhoef et al., 2015, p. 176) and is the focus of this section, as it most directly aligns with how live streaming shopping might activate offline store visits. Webrooming is primarily driven by two complementary mechanisms: information processing and uncertainty reduction (Flavián et al., 2020, p. 2). Consumers use online resources to assess their options, gather product information, and compare alternative options, a process which reduces uncertainty. However, for certain product categories, especially those that require sensory evaluation like apparel or cosmetics, online information alone is often insufficient to fully eliminate any remaining uncertainty related to fit, texture, or quality. In such cases, the physical store visit serves as the final step in the decision-making process, allowing consumers to evaluate the product through direct sensory experience before committing to a purchase (Flavián et al., 2020, p. 2).

As discussed in Section 2.1.3, LSS has limitations for high-touch products that require sensory evaluation. In these cases, augmented reality is more effective (Sun et al., 2026, p. 12). As a result, LSS may function as a driver for webrooming behavior, reducing uncertainty to build purchase interest, while leaving a residual sensory gap that motivates a later store visit.

Recent research provides further indications of the conditions under which webrooming occurs. Stephen et al. (2025, p. 835) report a positive association between a satisfying online research experience and the intention to purchase offline. While correlational evidence of this kind cannot by itself establish whether online research substitutes for or reinforces offline purchasing, it is consistent with the empirical findings of Verhoef et al. (2007, p. 140), who show that internet search followed by an in-store purchase constitutes the most frequent form of research shopping. Taken together, these findings suggest that a satisfying digital interaction is more likely to prepare an offline purchase than to displace it.

ROPO is directional by definition, describing online research followed by an offline purchase. The broader omnichannel journey in which it is embedded, however, is not. Consumers may also conduct online research while shopping in-store or immediately after a store visit (Stephen et al., 2025, p. 837), which indicates that the boundaries separating online and offline shopping activities are fluid rather than fixed. This is consistent with the omnichannel perspective outlined in Section 2.2.1 and with the observation that consumers move repeatedly between channels while gathering information and adjusting their preferences before reaching a purchase decision (Verhoef et al., 2015, p. 175). For the present study, this implies that the relevance of LSS is not exhausted by its direct effect on online purchasing. By reducing uncertainty and strengthening consumer confidence, LSS may also shape subsequent behavior in other channels, including physical stores. It is therefore treated here as one touchpoint within a broader omnichannel customer journey.

2.3 Behavioral Mechanisms Linking LSS to Offline Behavior

2.3.1 Brand Familiarity and Trust

One significant way in which live streaming shopping can affect future offline consumer behavior is by establishing brand familiarity and trust. While Section 2.1 demonstrated that LSS can reduce product uncertainty and generate experiential value, this section elaborates on how repeated exposure to this retail format fosters familiarity and trust. This makes consumers more willing to engage with the brand in physical stores. In the context of LSS, trust operates on two levels: "trust in the seller and trust in the product" (Wongkitrungrueng & Assarut, 2020, p. 544). Trust in the product refers to consumers' confidence in its quality and whether it is suitable for their needs. Trust in the seller, on the other hand, is a personal form of trust directed at the host. These two dimensions are not independent. Trust in the seller mediates the relationship between perceived value and engagement, ultimately influencing purchase intention (Wongkitrungrueng & Assarut, 2020, p. 552). The host plays a key role in building trust. There are two ways in which broadcasters can reduce consumer uncertainty in live streaming commerce. The first way is product-centered. The host demonstrates the product, enabling consumers with similar physical attributes to evaluate its suitability (Lu & Chen, 2021, p. 1). The second way focuses on social interaction. Through repeated synchronous interactions, the host builds a personal relationship of trust with the viewer. Consumers who trust a broadcaster believe that they will recommend good, suitable products, which increases purchase intention (Lu & Chen, 2021, p. 1). This trust-building process is supported by the parasocial interaction mechanism discussed in Section 2.1.2. Regular exposure to the same host creates a feeling of intimacy and familiarity that extends beyond a single broadcast. Over time, consumers begin to see the host as a trusted friend rather than merely a salesperson (Wongkitrungrueng & Assarut, 2020, p. 545). This psychological closeness reduces the perceived risk of making purchase decisions and makes consumers more open to the host's product recommendations. LSS helps to boost brand familiarity, in addition to fostering trust in the individual host. Consumers develop a more detailed and emotionally connected view of a brand when they regularly see its products, values and style in a live streaming setting. This familiarity reduces the mental effort necessary for future purchase decisions and increases the likelihood of brand-related actions across different channels (Long et al., 2024, p. 3). Influencer streamers play a significant part in this process. Their reputation and capacity to influence shape consumer attitudes towards the brand (Barta et al., 2023, p. 4), strengthening the motivation to engage with it and the perceived social norms surrounding it (Long et al., 2024, p. 3).

While trust and familiarity influence the customers brand view over time, LSS can also quickly shape offline behavior. This is achieved by reducing product uncertainty through real-time demonstration. This will be the focus of the following section.

2.3.2 Uncertainty Reduction through Product Demonstration

As discussed in the previous sections, LSS helps consumers become more familiar with a brand while reducing product-related uncertainty through real-time product demonstrations and interaction. However, these methods do not provide a full explanation of why many consumers continue their shopping journey by visiting a physical store. A key reason for this is that digital channels cannot provide direct touch experiences. Physical touch is an essential part of evaluating products, especially those with quality-related concerns such as material, texture, or fit. When consumers are unable to physically examine a product, their confidence in their assessment is diminished because they miss important tactile information (Peck & Childers, 2003, p. 35). This limitation also applies to LSS. More recent work in digital and omnichannel settings confirms that the constraint persists in online formats, where the inability to touch a product remains a central reason why consumers who research digitally continue their journey in a physical store (Flavián et al., 2016, p. 460; Hwang & Youn, 2023, p. 7). Regardless of the interactive or realistic nature of a live stream, consumers cannot directly experience the product. Research on fashion live streaming further shows the strong link between online and offline information searches. Consumers who usually rely on inspecting products in physical stores also look for similar information during live streaming shopping (Hwang & Youn, 2023, pp. 6-7). In the current market, there is a high demand for product demonstrations, interaction with the seller, and reviews from other users. These results suggest that LSS replicates many of the informational roles of a physical store in a digital space (Hwang & Youn, 2023, p. 7). However, it is important to note that it cannot fully substitute for the sensory information that consumers gain from directly interacting with a product (Peck & Childers, 2003, p. 35). Consequently, visiting a physical store may be a logical next step in the customer journey, especially when consumers wish to verify product features that cannot be assessed online (Flavián et al., 2016, p. 460). From this perspective, a store visit should not be seen as an indicator of consumers' distrust of the digital channel. It can instead be understood as the final stage of a decision-making process that largely began online. By the time consumers enter the store, much of the cognitive uncertainty surrounding the product may already have been reduced by LSS, leaving mainly sensory aspects to be evaluated. Accordingly, LSS can be viewed as a touchpoint that prepares consumers for subsequent engagement with the physical store, rather than replacing it.

2.3.3 Value Transfer across Channels

As demonstrated in previous sections, LSS has the capacity to enhance brand recognition and trust, whilst simultaneously mitigating product-related uncertainty. However, a significant proportion of consumers still prefer to shop in physical stores because of the lack of physical interaction with products (Peck & Childers, 2003, p. 35). The remaining question is how these experiences connect across different channels. Instead of ending with the live stream, positive experiences with LSS may influence consumers' behavior at later touchpoints (Lemon & Verhoef, 2016, p. 76). Cross-channel reinforcement is a concept that underlies the integration of LSS into a comprehensive omnichannel customer journey, emphasizing its role as a constituent element of a cohesive digital sales strategy.

The theoretical basis for this idea was introduced in Section 2.2.3. As stated by Verhoef et al. (2007, p. 132), cross-channel synergy is defined as the process by which positive experiences in one channel improve consumers' evaluations and use of another channel. Research indicates that consumers are particularly influenced by online product information when making purchasing decisions in physical stores (Verhoef et al., 2007, p. 140). This pattern closely resembles the role LSS may play in the customer journey. Consequently, a positive live streaming experience can influence consumers' perceptions of the digital channel and their feelings about the retailer's physical stores. Further evidence comes from studies on integrating online and offline channels. Herhausen et al. (2015, p. 320) demonstrate that the incorporation of physical store information into the online shopping experience fosters channel synergies rather than fostering competition between channels. This integration serves to mitigate risk perceptions and enhance quality perceptions, ultimately leading to favorable outcomes for both channels. In the context of LSS, these findings suggest that live streams can enhance consumers' knowledge of the brand and its products, complementing their offline interactions instead of replacing them. Research on LSS also supports this idea. Yuan et al. (2026, p. 802) found that consumers who experienced a strong sense of flow during a live stream reported less post-purchase regret and more enjoyment. According to Lemon and Verhoef (2016, p. 76), experiences at one touchpoint shape how consumers engage with subsequent touchpoints in their journey. These positive sentiments may not be confined to the live stream, as they can influence consumers' propensity to engage with the brand through other channels. This suggests that a positive LSS experience may increase the likelihood of consumers visiting a physical store in the future. The literature indicates that the advantages of LSS extend beyond the digital realm. Trust, brand familiarity, and positive emotional experiences can carry over to other channels, making a visit to a physical store a continuation of the customer journey rather than an alternative. This study investigates the conditions under which consumers apply the value created by LSS to the offline retail environment and whether this leads to complementary or substitutive channel behavior. These relationships form the foundation of the conceptual framework discussed in the next section.

2.4 Conceptual Framework

2.4.1 LSS as Omnichannel Activation Mechanism

As the previous sections have shown, live streaming shopping should be understood as being more than just a standalone digital sales channel. Through real-time product demonstrations and interaction, LSS reduces consumers' product-related uncertainty. At the same time, repeated exposure to the brand and interaction with the host foster trust and brand familiarity. As discussed previously, these positive experiences are not confined to the live stream itself but can extend across different channels through cross-channel synergy. Taken together, these mechanisms suggest that LSS functions as a touchpoint within a broader omnichannel customer journey, rather than as an isolated point of purchase. Consequently, its value may lie not only in generating immediate online sales, but also in encouraging subsequent offline behavior, including visits to physical stores. This perspective is closely linked to the ROPO and webrooming literature discussed in Section 2.2.3. While LSS can address much of the cognitive uncertainty surrounding a purchase decision, digital formats cannot entirely replicate the sensory information consumers obtain through physical product interaction. As Peck and Childers (2003, p. 35) argue, the absence of haptic information reduces consumers' confidence in evaluating products. For product categories in which touch plays an important role in particular, this remaining sensory uncertainty may motivate consumers to continue their shopping journey in a physical store. From this perspective, a store visit should not necessarily be interpreted as an LSS failure to convert consumers online. Rather, it may indicate that the LSS has provided sufficient information and trust to enable consumers to feel confident in taking the final step of evaluating and purchasing the product in person.

2.4.2 Synergy vs. Cannibalization

While the previous section explains why LSS has the potential to encourage offline behavior, this effect should not be regarded as inevitable. Research in the omnichannel literature shows that digital and physical channels do not always reinforce one another. Depending on the retail context and the way channels are integrated, they may either complement each other or compete for the same sales. A review of fifty empirical retailing studies illustrates this complexity. The introduction of an online channel can even lead to cannibalization of offline sales, although the magnitude of this effect varies considerably across retail settings (Timoumi et al., 2022, pp. 11-12). In that review, the reported impact is negligible in some settings, whereas in others it exceeds 90 percent (Timoumi et al., 2022, pp. 11-12). At the same time, the review shows that retailers generally benefit from adopting an online channel, as overall firm performance tends to improve even when some degree of channel cannibalization occurs (Timoumi et al., 2022, p. 13). A concrete illustration is provided by research on buy online, pick up in store (BOPS), which shares several characteristics with the activation mechanism proposed for LSS in this study. In a quasi-experimental study of a durable goods retailer, Gallino and Moreno (2014) find that the introduction of BOPS reduced online sales while increasing store traffic and in-store sales, resulting in a net gain overall. They attribute this shift to a research-shopper mechanism: providing reliable online inventory information encouraged consumers to complete in the physical store a purchase process that had been initiated online. Findings on the addition of informational websites to existing offline retailers paint a more differentiated picture of the relationship between online and offline channels. Although one study found that website access reduced shopping frequency and offline spending across several product categories, a related study based on the same dataset showed that these effects vary considerably across customer segments and product types. For some consumers, particularly those purchasing sensory products or living farther away from the store, online search complemented subsequent offline purchases. For others, however, online information substituted for the in-store shopping experience (Timoumi et al., 2022, p. 14).

Applied to the context of LSS, these findings suggest that its ability to activate offline behavior is likely to depend on several conditions rather than occurring automatically. Factors such as the experiential nature of the product, the strength of the parasocial relationship with the host, and the extent to which the live stream builds trust and credibility may all influence whether consumers continue their journey in a physical store or complete the purchase online. Identifying these boundary conditions represents a central objective of the present study.

2.4.3 Research Questions

Building on the theoretical framework developed in this chapter, the present study seeks to answer the following research questions:

RQ1: Under what conditions does live streaming shopping encourage consumers to visit a physical store?

RQ2: How do trust, brand familiarity, and residual uncertainty interact in motivating offline continuation?

RQ3: Under what circumstances does live streaming shopping complement physical retail, and under what circumstances does it substitute for in-store purchasing?

These research questions guide the qualitative research design presented in the following chapter. By combining consumer focus groups with an interview involving a retail manager, the study aims to examine both the consumer-side mechanisms underlying offline activation and the managerial perspective on channel complementarity.

3 Methodology

3.1 Research Aim and Approach

This study pursues an exploratory, interpretivist research aim. Rather than measuring the frequency with which live streaming shopping leads to offline purchases, it seeks to understand how consumers experience the transition from a livestream to a physical store and which conditions make this transition more or less likely. The design combines two consumer focus groups with one semi-structured expert interview in order to capture both the consumer and the retailer perspective on the same phenomenon. The following sections justify this methodological choice, describe the data collection procedure, and outline the analytical approach.

3.2 Justification of Method Selection

A qualitative research design was considered the most appropriate approach for this study because the objective is not to measure the prevalence of specific behaviors but to develop a deeper understanding of how consumers experience live streaming shopping and how these experiences influence subsequent offline behavior. More specifically, the study seeks to explore under which conditions LSS encourages consumers to visit a physical store and how the underlying mechanisms are perceived from both the consumer and the retailer perspective.

To capture these complementary perspectives, two qualitative methods were combined. Consumer focus groups were selected because they are particularly well suited to exploring motivations, perceptions, and decision-making processes. Among the three approaches to qualitative marketing research distinguished by Calder (1977, pp. 355-356), exploratory, clinical, and phenomenological, the present use of focus groups is closest to what Calder terms the phenomenological orientation, in the sense that the groups were used to access consumers' everyday experience of livestream shopping rather than to generate or test scientific constructs (Calder, 1977, p. 356). This should not be read as a claim that the study as a whole follows a phenomenological methodology. The overall design is exploratory and interpretivist, and the material was analyzed thematically following Braun and Clarke (2006), as set out in Section 3.4. The interactive group setting encourages participants to build on each other's experiences, allowing both shared views and contrasting perspectives to emerge.

To complement the consumer perspective, a semi-structured expert interview was conducted with a retail manager. This made it possible to explore strategic and operational considerations regarding the relationship between digital and physical channels, including perceived synergies and the potential substitution between channels, which consumers themselves are not in a position to evaluate.

3.3 Conducting the Interviews

Data collection consisted of two consumer focus groups and one semi-structured expert interview. The first focus group comprised five participants, while the second included four participants. Participants were recruited through convenience sampling within the researcher's personal and professional networks. Participants were required to have had at least some prior exposure to live streaming shopping and to shop across both online and offline channels. Beyond this minimum requirement, the sample was deliberately composed to vary in the intensity of livestream use, ranging from participants who watched streams on a near-weekly basis to participants with only two or three prior exposures, and in channel preference, including participants who described themselves as predominantly online shoppers as well as participants who preferred physical stores. This variation was intended to ensure that the discussions would surface not only accounts of successful transitions from livestream to store but also accounts in which the format had little influence, consistent with the attention paid to divergent cases in the analysis. Both focus groups were conducted online via video call and lasted approximately 83 and 79 minutes, respectively.

The expert interview was conducted with a Brand & Digital Retail Manager working for a mid-sized European fashion retailer operating both physical stores and an e-commerce platform. The interviewee was responsible for the company's live streaming shopping activities as well as the coordination between digital and offline retail operations. The interview was conducted via video call and lasted approximately 62 minutes.

The nine focus group participants were between 23 and 45 years of age and covered a range of shopping profiles, from predominantly online to predominantly in-store, as well as a range of product interests including fashion, skincare and grooming, furniture and home goods, electronics, sneakers and kitchenware. Their exposure to livestream shopping ranged from near-weekly viewing to two or three streams in total. A full overview of participants is provided in Appendix C.

Both instruments were structured around the three research questions developed in Section 2.4.3. The focus group guide (Appendix A) moves from general shopping behavior and prior experience with LSS, through the in-stream experience and the perception of the host, to remaining product uncertainty, the transition to the physical store, and the perceived connection between channels. Sections 4 and 5 of that guide therefore address RQ1, Section 3 addresses RQ2, and Sections 6 and 7 address RQ3. The expert interview guide (Appendix B) follows a parallel logic at the organizational level, covering the strategic objectives of LSS, observed customer behavior, the role of the physical store within the customer journey, channel integration, and performance measurement, so that its Sections 4, 3 and 5 correspond to RQ1, RQ2 and RQ3 respectively. In both cases the questions served as thematic prompts rather than as a fixed script. All focus group discussions and the expert interview were conducted in German. Transcripts were produced in the original language and subsequently translated into English by the researcher. Quotations reported in Chapter 4 were translated with a focus on conveying the participants' meaning rather than providing a literal rendering.

All interviews were audio-recorded with participants’ consent and fully anonymized in accordance with the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR). The recordings were transcribed with the support of automated transcription software (TripleScribe) and subsequently checked and corrected manually by the researcher against the audio. The working transcripts used for coding were verbatim, in the sense that they reproduced everything participants said, including hesitations and repetitions. Only for the quotations reported in Chapter 4 were obvious filler words, false starts, and repeated phrases removed, in order to improve readability while leaving the meaning of the statements unchanged. The discussion guides are provided in Appendix A and B; an overview of participants is presented in Appendix C.

Both focus groups fell at the lower end of the size range commonly recommended in the literature, which generally suggests between six and ten participants for applied focus group research (Krueger & Casey, 2015). This was a deliberate design choice for the first group and a practical necessity for the second, where one recruited participant was unable to attend. Smaller groups were considered acceptable given the exploratory aim of the study and the relatively narrow topic focus: with fewer participants, each individual had substantially more speaking time, which supported the detailed, experience-centered accounts that this orientation requires. The trade-off is a reduced diversity of perspectives within each session, which is addressed in Section 8.1.

3.4 Data Analysis

The collected data were analyzed using thematic analysis following the six-phase framework proposed by Braun and Clarke (2006). This method was considered particularly appropriate because the study aims to identify recurring patterns in participants' experiences while allowing sufficient flexibility to capture unexpected insights that emerged during the interviews.

The analysis followed a hybrid coding approach, combining deductive and inductive elements. The conceptual framework developed in Chapter 2 informed an initial set of deductive codes based on key concepts such as brand familiarity, trust, residual product uncertainty, and cross-channel synergy. At the same time, the analysis remained open to additional themes that emerged directly from participants' accounts and were not fully reflected in the existing literature.

Following Braun and Clarke's (2006) six phases, the analysis began with repeated reading of all transcripts to achieve familiarity with the data. Initial codes were then generated across both the focus groups and the expert interview. This process produced 33 codes in total, of which 15 were derived deductively from the conceptual framework developed in Chapter 2 and 18 emerged inductively from the data. These codes were subsequently consolidated into eight themes, six of which are carried into the analysis of the three research questions, while two are reported as supplementary findings. The full coding scheme, including code definitions and the distribution of codes across the dataset, is documented in Appendix D. These codes captured participants' descriptions of experiences and behaviors, including aspects such as product demonstration, the credibility of the livestream host, remaining information needs, motivations for visiting physical stores, and perceived interactions between online and offline channels. In the subsequent phases, related codes were organized into broader themes, reviewed and refined, and ultimately linked to the three research questions developed in Section 2.4.3.

Particular attention was paid to divergent or disconfirming cases throughout the analysis. Rather than being treated as outliers, instances in which participants reported that LSS had little or no influence on their offline behavior were analyzed as important boundary conditions. This approach allowed the analysis not only to identify the mechanisms through which LSS may encourage physical store visits, but also to better understand the circumstances under which these mechanisms do not operate.

The transcripts were coded manually using a spreadsheet-based coding table rather than dedicated qualitative analysis software, which was considered appropriate given the size of the dataset. Coding was carried out by the researcher alone, as no second coder was available. Rather than pursuing inter-coder reliability, which is contested within interpretivist approaches to thematic analysis, transparency was sought through documentation of the coding scheme (Appendix D) and through the explicit treatment of divergent cases. Data collection was not continued to the point of theoretical saturation; with two focus groups and one expert interview, the analysis does not claim that no further themes would have emerged, and the aim was depth of description rather than exhaustive thematic coverage.

4 Results

This chapter presents the findings of the thematic analysis. The results are organized around the three research questions introduced in Section 2.4.3. Following the research design outlined in Chapter 3, the findings from the consumer focus groups are presented first, followed by the insights from the expert interview. This structure allows similarities and differences between both perspectives to become visible before they are interpreted in the discussion chapter.

4.1 RQ1: Under what conditions does live streaming shopping encourage consumers to visit a physical store?

4.1.1 Consumer Perspective

Across both focus groups, participants did not describe visiting a physical store as an automatic consequence of watching a livestream. Instead, store visits occurred only under certain conditions, which differed across participants and product categories.

One recurring factor was the availability of practical information during the livestream. Sofia explained that a small on-screen overlay showing which nearby stores stocked the featured product influenced her decision to visit a physical store. Rather than making a dedicated shopping trip, she combined the visit with plans she already had:

"I worked it into a Saturday I was already going to be there. The stream created the intention and the circumstances created the opportunity." (Sofia, FG1).

For Sofia, the livestream therefore became part of a broader shopping journey rather than an isolated purchasing event.

Participants across both groups contrasted the informational depth of the livestream with standard online product presentations. Lina described the value of being able to compare sizes on the same body within a single stream:

"Seeing the same item on the same person in different sizes, back to back. That comparison is so useful. And the host's commentary about what she would size up or down on - that kind of practical insight doesn't exist in a standard product listing." (Lina, FG1).

Marcel made a comparable point about real-time responses to specific questions, and Elena described seeing a sofa cushion compress and recover under the host's weight as information entirely absent from a product photo.

Several participants also linked store visits to products involving higher financial commitment. Elena described travelling around two hours to visit a furniture showroom after watching a livestream featuring a sofa. Although the livestream had already answered most of her questions, one aspect remained that she wanted to experience herself, namely the firmness of the cushions.

"I went in with specific questions, a specific product reference, and a specific remaining uncertainty to resolve. […] The stream had already done the consideration phase." (Elena, FG2).

She further explained that the livestream had considerably narrowed down her options before the store visit.

"Without the stream I probably would have needed to visit two or three stores just to narrow down my options." (Elena, FG2).

Other participants reported different experiences. For technology products, Jona explained that additional information was generally available online and that visiting a store offered little additional value.

"For tech everything I need to know is either discoverable online or it's not and no store visit would help either." (Jona, FG1).

This did not mean that no uncertainty remained. Jona identified sound quality as an attribute that a livestream cannot convey at all, describing the format as poorly suited to audio products. He resolved the remaining question through independent online reviews after the stream, describing this as a step he would have taken in any case. Residual uncertainty therefore persisted in his case but was resolved within the digital environment rather than through a store visit.

Similarly, Klara described how her uncertainty about a skincare product was resolved directly during the livestream through interaction with the host.

"The live Q&A element closed the gap for me. Without that, I probably would have hesitated." (Klara, FG1).

Marcel described an equivalent sequence for a grooming product, where a question about an ingredient interaction was answered by the host within the stream. In both cases the open question was chemical or informational rather than sensory, and the format was able to resolve it directly.

For Ahmet, the structure of sneaker releases made physical store visits largely impractical. He explained that limited releases often sold out before he would have been able to visit a store.

"By the time I could get to a store the product is gone [...]." (Ahmet, FG2).

Not every participant attempted to resolve remaining uncertainty through another channel. Chanti described deciding against purchasing a kitchen product because she remained uncertain about its long-term durability.

"I decided not to buy. The durability question was too important to me and there was no way to resolve it through the stream. So I walked away." (Chanti, FG2).

Across the focus groups, these accounts illustrate that participants responded differently to remaining uncertainty. Depending on the product and the situation, uncertainty was resolved during the livestream itself, through a subsequent store visit, by accepting the remaining risk, or by abandoning the purchase altogether.

4.1.2 Manager Perspective

The expert interview provided a complementary perspective on the conditions under which a livestream leads customers into a physical store. Rather than describing this transition as a general effect of the format, Manager A related it to the informational requirements of the product category presented.

According to the manager, products requiring more consideration, such as outerwear, were more likely to encourage customers to continue their shopping journey in-store. Simpler products, such as basic T-shirts, were by contrast more likely to be purchased directly during the livestream without leading to a subsequent store visit. Manager A explicitly linked this distinction to the objective set for a given stream.

"For a plain t-shirt, maximise in-stream conversion. For an outerwear piece, design the stream to drive a confident store visit." (Manager A).

This differentiation corresponds closely to the accounts reported in Section 4.1.1, where participants described store visits primarily in connection with products involving higher financial commitment or a remaining physical evaluation. From the manager's perspective, the conditions under which a livestream encourages a store visit are therefore defined less by the format itself than by the informational and experiential requirements of the product presented.

4.2 RQ2: How do trust, brand familiarity, and residual uncertainty interact in motivating offline continuation?

4.2.1 Consumer Perspective

Across both focus groups, participants repeatedly referred to three mechanisms that influenced whether they continued their customer journey beyond the livestream: trust in the host and the brand, remaining product uncertainty, and previous familiarity with the brand. While these mechanisms often interacted, participants described them in different ways depending on the product category and their previous shopping experience.

Trust and parasocial familiarity

One of the clearest patterns across both focus groups was that trust in the brand often developed through trust in the livestream host. Rather than separating the two, several participants described the host as their first point of reference when evaluating unfamiliar brands.

Klara explained that her confidence in the brand developed gradually through repeated exposure to the host:

"I trusted the host first and that trust kind of migrated to the brand over time. [...] The brand's credibility built on top of that foundation." (Klara, FG1).

Lina described a similar experience, explaining that she would probably not have considered purchasing from the brand without first encountering it through the livestream.

"If I'd encountered the brand through a regular ad I probably wouldn't have given them a second look." (Lina, FG1).

Several participants also emphasized that trust increased when hosts openly acknowledged the limitations of the livestream rather than presenting products as flawless. Sofia recalled a fashion livestream in which the presenter openly flagged a limitation of the format, telling viewers that "the white version might look slightly different in person depending on your lighting at home, just so you know" (Sofia, FG1, reporting the host).

Rather than reducing her confidence, Sofia explained that this honesty increased her trust in both the presenter and the brand.

A comparable experience emerged in the second focus group. Elena remembered a furniture livestream in which the host stated that the stream "won't fully capture the cushion firmness" (Elena, FG2, reporting the host) and explicitly recommended visiting the showroom to assess it.

Elena described this openness as one of the reasons she considered the presenter trustworthy and subsequently decided to make the visit.

Not all participants viewed this relationship uncritically. Michael questioned whether such trust should be interpreted as a genuinely personal relationship, noting that the interaction ultimately remained commercial.

"Because it's still fundamentally a commercial relationship, right? Even if it feels personal." (Michael, FG1).

Similarly, Marcel explained that although he regularly followed one particular creator, he consciously checked product information independently before making a purchase.

"I use his recommendations as a starting point, not an endpoint. I still read the ingredient list myself." (Marcel, FG2).

These accounts suggest that participants differed in the extent to which they relied on the host, with some describing strong personal trust while others deliberately maintained a more critical distance.

Remaining product uncertainty

Another recurring topic across both focus groups was the role of remaining uncertainty after watching a livestream. However, the type of uncertainty differed considerably across product categories.

For fashion products, participants mainly referred to aspects such as fabric feel, fit, and sizing. Sofia described the two attributes that the stream had left open for her:

"Whether the fabric would feel as breathable as described - there's no way to experience that through a screen. And honestly whether the white would look see-through on me, because the stream lighting was pretty controlled and flattering." (Sofia, FG1).

Durable household products prompted concerns about long-term quality, as illustrated by Chanti's decision not to purchase a kitchen product. Jona highlighted a further limitation for audio equipment, arguing that livestreams could not adequately convey sound quality. Skincare and grooming followed a different pattern: both Klara and Marcel described their remaining uncertainty, in each case a question of individual skin compatibility or ingredient interaction, as having been resolved within the stream itself through the chat function (see Section 4.1.1). This contrast suggests that whether residual uncertainty persists depends less on the product category as such than on whether the open question is sensory in nature and therefore not addressable through the format.

Participants described several ways of dealing with these remaining uncertainties. Some resolved their questions directly during the livestream through interaction with the host or other viewers. Others chose to visit a physical store to experience the product themselves. In some cases, participants accepted a degree of uncertainty and proceeded with the purchase, while others decided not to purchase the product at all.

Rather than following a single decision path, participants described different responses depending on the type of information they still considered necessary before making a purchase decision.

Brand familiarity

Previous experience with a brand also influenced participants' decision-making. Several participants explained that familiarity reduced the need to seek further information through either the livestream or a physical store. Lina described this particularly clearly when discussing clothing purchases.

"I generally just don't buy unless I already know that brand's sizing well enough to feel safe." (Lina, FG1).

For her, previous experience with the brand largely removed the uncertainty that would otherwise require additional information. Other participants expressed similar views, explaining that familiar brands required considerably less verification before purchasing than unfamiliar ones.

Overall, the focus groups suggest that brand familiarity shaped how much additional information participants felt they needed after watching a livestream. For some, familiarity allowed them to purchase immediately, whereas unfamiliar brands often prompted further information seeking through other channels.

Taken together, the three mechanisms did not operate independently. Brand familiarity determined how much information participants required in the first place; trust in the host determined whether the information provided during the livestream was accepted as reliable; and residual uncertainty determined whether an information need remained that could only be resolved elsewhere. Participants familiar with a brand described little residual uncertainty regardless of the host, whereas participants encountering a brand for the first time relied on the host to establish the credibility of the information against which their remaining uncertainty was assessed.

4.2.2 Manager Perspective

The manager interview reflected many of the themes that emerged in the consumer discussions. According to Manager A, trust played an important role in the success of livestream shopping, particularly because customers often relied on the presenter's personal experience rather than solely on product descriptions.

Describing the company's main livestream host, Manager A explained:

"She'll say, 'I sized up because I like it slightly loose,' or 'this runs narrow across the shoulders, be aware.'" (Manager A).

Manager A linked the effectiveness of this information less to its content than to the perceived relationship between host and audience.

"If she says it runs narrow, they believe her, because they feel they know her." (Manager A).

From the manager's perspective, this type of information provided customers with practical guidance that was difficult to communicate through standard product pages. Manager A also reported an internal observation that products presented extensively by the host tended to generate fewer returns than products that received less detailed explanation. It should be emphasized that this is the manager's account of a pattern noticed within the company rather than the result of a formal analysis. No test was carried out to establish that the livestream caused the lower return rate, and differences in product type, price or assortment could equally account for it. Within the company, however, the pattern was read as an indication that customers made more informed purchase decisions after watching the livestream.

Brand familiarity also emerged as an important factor from the firm's perspective. According to Manager A, existing customers who were already familiar with the brand generally required fewer additional steps before purchasing, whereas first-time customers often continued their information search beyond the livestream.

"We have customers who've been buying from us for years and trust our sizing completely [...]. New customers, or customers who are still learning the brand, tend to need more steps." (Manager A).

Finally, the manager highlighted a challenge that was not discussed extensively by consumers: the company's dependence on individual hosts. While authentic presenters were viewed as one of the main strengths of livestream shopping, this also created organizational vulnerability, which the manager described as a recognized but not yet resolved issue.

"There's a legitimate risk question, what happens if she leaves, or if something happens to the relationship? [...] you can't manufacture authenticity." (Manager A).

Taken together, the manager interview largely supports the patterns identified in the consumer focus groups. Trust, previous familiarity with the brand, and the remaining need for product information all appeared to influence whether customers completed their purchase immediately or continued their shopping journey through additional channels.

4.3 RQ3: Under what circumstances does live streaming shopping complement physical retail, and under what circumstances does it substitute for in-store purchasing?

4.3.1 Consumer Perspective

Participants rarely reflected explicitly on whether live streaming shopping complemented or replaced physical store purchases. Nevertheless, their accounts provided insights into how they perceived the relationship between online and offline channels. Where participants had experienced a transition from livestream to store, they generally described it positively. Sofia recalled that the livestream had given her a largely accurate picture of the garment, with one discrepancy: under the store lighting the white version proved more sheer than the stream had suggested, and she bought a different colour instead.

"Surprisingly seamless. [...] I was actually prepared for a disconnect and there wasn't really one." (Sofia, FG1).

She explained that this consistency strengthened her confidence in the retailer and made the shopping experience feel coherent across channels.

Other participants reacted with surprise when Sofia described this experience. Lina and Michael both commented that they would normally expect some inconsistency between online and offline channels, suggesting that seamless integration was perceived as something unusual rather than standard practice. At the same time, participants described situations in which a physical store did not play a meaningful role after watching a livestream. Ahmet returned to the case of limited sneaker releases discussed in Section 4.1.1, where products regularly sold out before a store visit would have been feasible, or were not stocked by the store in the first place.

For him, this was not experienced as a weakness of the retailer but rather as an accepted characteristic of sneaker culture. Under these conditions, purchasing through the livestream or online was considered the only realistic option.

A structurally different case emerged for Klara and Marcel. Both bought predominantly from brands operating exclusively direct-to-consumer, meaning that no physical store existed in which the journey could have been continued. For them the question of complementarity did not arise, since the offline channel was absent rather than unattractive.

Overall, the focus groups suggest that participants did not perceive online and offline channels as inherently competing with one another. Instead, the relationship depended on the product category, the shopping situation, and whether visiting a physical store offered additional value.

4.3.2 Manager Perspective

The expert interview provided a broader organizational perspective on the relationship between livestream shopping and physical retail. Rather than describing the two channels as either complementary or competing in general, Manager A explained that this relationship varied depending on the product category and the objectives of different business units. According to the manager, livestream shopping sometimes created differing priorities within the organization.

"There's a tension, basically, between the e-commerce perspective, which wants to drive online conversion, maximize in-stream sales, keep the customer on the platform, and the retail operations perspective, which is understandably focused on footfall and in-store performance. Those aren't always the same objective." (Manager A).

Manager A located this tension explicitly at the level of internal functions rather than customer behavior.

"There's genuine tension between our e-commerce function, which wants to own the stream and maximise online conversion, and our retail operations function, which worries about cannibalization of store traffic." (Manager A).

The manager considered both positions legitimate but noted that the resulting compromises were sometimes suboptimal for the customer journey. The concern was also qualified by product category: cannibalization was regarded as a plausible risk for basics and lower-involvement items rather than as a general effect.

This illustrates that livestream shopping is not evaluated solely by its online sales performance but also by its potential influence on physical stores. It is important to be precise about what this evidence shows. The concern described here is a perceived risk of substitution held within the retail operations function, not a demonstrated cannibalization effect. As the manager makes clear below, the company holds no data that would allow such an effect either to be established or to be ruled out. Building on the category differentiation described in Section 4.1.2, Manager A also assessed the relationship between the two channels differently depending on the type of product involved.

"For higher-consideration products, I think the relationship is more likely to be complementary than competitive." (Manager A).

Manager A also reported indirect evidence of offline continuation from the store network. Store managers had repeatedly observed customers referring to livestream content on arrival.

"Managers report customers coming in and specifically asking about a piece from 'the video' or 'the TikTok', their terminology varies. Some arrive with screenshots on their phones of something the host wore." (Manager A).

Manager A characterized this reporting as unsystematic, describing it as conversational feedback passed along informally rather than collected through a formal mechanism.

Despite these observations, Manager A repeatedly emphasized that the company currently lacked the data needed to evaluate these effects systematically.

"We cannot currently connect a livestream viewer to a subsequent in-store purchase. There's no shared identifier, no tracking mechanism." (Manager A).

As a result, many assumptions about the offline impact of livestream shopping were based on informal feedback of this kind rather than on formal performance metrics. Rather than viewing online and offline channels as competing alternatives, the interview therefore indicates that they can fulfill different functions within the same customer journey, although the organization is currently unable to verify this empirically.

Taken together, both the consumer and manager data point to a similar conclusion. Participants did not describe a single relationship between livestream shopping and physical stores. Instead, the interaction between channels appeared to depend on the specific shopping context, the product category, and the role that the physical store continued to play in the customer's decision-making process.

5 Discussion

This chapter compares the empirical findings presented in Chapter 4 with the theoretical framework developed in Chapter 2. The purpose is not to reintroduce the participants' accounts in detail, but to examine how far the observed patterns confirm, extend, or diverge from existing research on omnichannel retailing, webrooming, and cross-channel value transfer. Broader theoretical implications and the integrated interpretation of these findings are reserved for Chapter 6.

5.1 Store Visits as Continuation Rather than Alternative (RQ1)

The findings summarized in Section 4.1 largely support the ROPO and webrooming logic outlined in Sections 2.2.3 and 2.3.2. Participants who visited a physical store after watching a livestream consistently described the visit not as a substitute for the digital channel but as a subsequent step within an ongoing decision-making process (see Section 4.1.1). This behavior aligns closely with the definition of cross-channel synergy proposed by Verhoef et al. (2007, p. 131-132), according to which the attractiveness of one channel as a search environment increases the attractiveness of another channel for purchase. Two observations from the data add nuance to this literature. First, in the two cases in which a store visit was reported, accessibility conditions appeared to shape how the visit was organized rather than whether it took place. Sofia's visit was facilitated by the integration of nearby-store information within the livestream and was combined with plans she already had, which supports the argument of Herhausen et al. (2015, p. 320) that integrating online and offline channel information mitigates perceived barriers and fosters synergies rather than competition. Elena, by contrast, undertook a journey of approximately two hours specifically to resolve one remaining sensory question about a high-investment product. Rather than contradicting one another, these accounts suggest that the effort consumers are willing to invest scales with perceived purchase involvement: where involvement is high, practical accessibility appears to lose importance, whereas for lower-involvement purchases the store visit is more likely to be embedded in existing routines. Given that only two store visits were reported across both focus groups, this pattern should be treated as a tentative interpretation requiring further investigation rather than an established boundary condition. For higher-involvement categories such as furniture and outerwear, the findings extend Peck and Childers' (2003, p. 35) argument regarding haptic limitations of digital channels. Whereas Peck and Childers frame the absence of touch primarily as a barrier to confident online evaluation, the present findings suggest that this limitation may also function as a driver of subsequent offline behavior when the livestream has adequately resolved cognitive uncertainty (see Sections 4.1.1 and 4.1.2). The managerial account reported in Section 4.1.2 converges with this interpretation from the opposite direction. The retailer deliberately assigns different objectives to livestreams depending on product category, treating immediate in-stream conversion as the goal for low-consideration items and the building of confidence for a store visit as the goal for higher-consideration ones. The condition identified on the consumer side therefore also appears as an explicit strategic assumption on the firm side. In other words, the sensory gap does not simply reduce online purchase likelihood; under certain conditions it redirects consumers towards a channel better suited to closing that specific gap. Different cases identified in Section 4.1.1 further sharpen this interpretation. For technology products and time-sensitive sneaker releases, participants did not continue their journey offline, either because online information was already considered sufficient or because the offline option was not practically available. These accounts underscore that the encouragement of store visits through LSS is neither automatic nor universal, but conditional on product characteristics and situational context. This is a point consistent with the qualified perspective on channel complementarity offered by Timoumi et al. (2022, pp. 11-12).

5.2 Trust, Familiarity, and Residual Uncertainty as Interacting Mechanisms (RQ2)

The mechanisms identified in Section 4.2 largely correspond to those anticipated in the conceptual framework developed in Section 2.4. However, the findings suggest that these mechanisms should not be treated as independent predictors but as interacting elements of a single evaluative process.

The observation that trust in the host frequently preceded and shaped trust in the brand (see Section 4.2.1) is consistent with Wongkitrungrueng and Assarut's (2020, p. 552) argument that trust in the seller mediates the relationship between perceived value and engagement. The findings are compatible with the theoretical distinction between trust in the product and trust in the seller and point to a possible sequence in which parasocial familiarity with the host serves as an entry point for broader brand-related trust. Because participants described their experiences retrospectively, the qualitative design cannot establish that this ordering holds generally, and the pattern is therefore presented as an interpretation of the accounts rather than as an established sequence. This is also compatible with the parasocial interaction perspective originally developed by Horton and Wohl (1956, p. 215) and applied to LSS by Wongkitrungrueng and Assarut (2020, p. 545).

A more distinctive finding concerns the role of host transparency. Participants across both focus groups reported that acknowledgments of the livestream's limitations, for example regarding fabric appearance under different lighting conditions or the impossibility of conveying cushion firmness through a screen, increased rather than reduced their trust in the host (see Section 4.2.1). This pattern is not directly addressed in the LSS literature, which tends to emphasize host attractiveness, expertise, and interactivity as the primary drivers of trust (Choi & Lee, 2019, p. 6; Wongkitrungrueng & Assarut, 2020, p. 545). The findings suggest that the credibility mechanism may operate in part through selective transparency, an aspect that appears to warrant further theoretical attention.

The role of brand familiarity as an uncertainty buffer (see Section 4.2.1) aligns with the arguments developed by Long et al. (2024, p. 3) regarding the role of familiarity in reducing cognitive effort during purchase decisions. Participants with prior experience of a brand described substantially fewer information-seeking behaviors after watching a livestream than participants encountering the brand for the first time, which is consistent with the theoretical expectation that familiarity reduces the marginal informational value of any single touchpoint.

Finally, the differentiation of residual uncertainty by product category (see Section 4.2.1) provides qualitative support for the argument advanced in Section 2.3.2 that the effectiveness of LSS in reducing uncertainty is bounded by the sensory demands of the product. This finding is consistent with the comparative analysis presented by Sun et al. (2026, p. 12), who report that LSS and augmented reality are equally effective for products with low experiential value but that AR outperforms LSS for high-experiential products. The present findings extend this argument by suggesting that, from the consumer perspective, LSS does not need to fully resolve sensory uncertainty in order to be effective; rather, its value may lie in narrowing that uncertainty to a single evaluable dimension.

5.3 Complementarity as a Conditional Rather than Uniform Outcome (RQ3)

The findings on the relationship between livestream shopping and physical retail (see Section 4.3) are consistent with the theoretical position developed in Section 2.4.2, according to which complementarity and substitution are not mutually exclusive outcomes but alternative possibilities that depend on contextual conditions. A qualification is necessary at this point. The present study can describe how consumers and one manager perceive the relationship between channels, but it cannot measure whether livestream sales actually displace store sales. Where the term cannibalization is used in the following, it therefore refers to a perceived or anticipated risk rather than to a demonstrated effect. This is broadly consistent with the review by Timoumi et al. (2022, pp. 11-12), which reports substantial variation in cannibalization effects across retail settings. The observation that participants with cross-channel experience described the transition between livestream and store as coherent (see Section 4.3.1) supports the argument of Gasparin et al. (2022, p. 5) that perceived connectivity between touchpoints plays a stronger role in shaping customer experience than perceived consistency alone. At the same time, the surprise expressed by other participants when hearing of such seamless transitions suggests that this level of connectivity remains the exception rather than the norm in current omnichannel practice. This is a point that supports the challenges to the "integration imperative" articulated by Gasparin et al. (2022, pp. 1-2). The manager perspective (see Sections 4.1.2 and 4.3.2) introduces an organizational dimension that is not fully addressed in the consumer-oriented literature. The manager's differentiation between product categories with different appropriate channel outcomes, and the acknowledgment of internal tensions between digital and store-focused teams, illustrates that the distinction between complementarity and substitution is also present at the level of organizational objectives, where it takes the form of competing internal priorities rather than of a measured effect on sales. This is particularly relevant given that the omnichannel literature increasingly emphasizes consumer-centric journey design (Lemon & Verhoef, 2016, p. 74; Gasparin et al., 2022, p. 9), while managerial practice may still be structured around channel-specific performance metrics. The measurement challenge identified in Section 4.3.2, i.e. the inability to attribute physical store outcomes to earlier livestream exposure, echoes methodological concerns raised in the omnichannel literature (Timoumi et al., 2022, p. 13). Whether this challenge is primarily technological or reflects a deeper characteristic of omnichannel behavior itself is a question that Chapter 6 examines in more detail.

5.4 Summary of the Discussion

Taken together, the findings largely confirm the theoretical mechanisms developed in Chapter 2 while suggesting several refinements. Cross-channel synergy in the sense of Verhoef et al. (2007, p. 131-132) is observable but appears to operate through conditional rather than uniform mechanisms. Trust develops in a sequential pattern in which the host functions as an entry point rather than a terminal source of credibility. Residual sensory uncertainty acts less as a limitation of LSS than as a directional signal that redirects consumers towards physically evaluable dimensions. Whether this reconfiguration of established mechanisms warrants an extended theoretical framework is the question addressed in the following chapter.

6 Interpretation

Whereas Chapter 5 discussed the findings in relation to the existing literature, the purpose of this chapter is to move beyond a comparison with previous studies and develop a broader interpretation of what the results collectively suggest. Rather than considering trust, uncertainty, channel integration, and store visits as isolated concepts, the findings indicate that these mechanisms are closely interconnected. Taken together, they offer a more nuanced understanding of the role of live streaming shopping within the omnichannel customer journey. In order not to duplicate the comparison with the literature already carried out in Chapter 5, this chapter concentrates on three interpretive steps that go beyond that comparison, before drawing them together into the exploratory framework presented in Section 6.4.

6.1 From Channel Choice to Information Sufficiency

One of the most striking patterns emerging from both the consumer focus groups and the manager interview is that participants rarely framed their decisions as a deliberate choice between an online and an offline channel. Instead, they appeared to evaluate whether they had obtained sufficient information to feel confident about making a purchase decision. From this perspective, the physical store is not necessarily preferred over the livestream, nor is the livestream viewed as a substitute for the store. Rather, consumers seem to move between channels depending on which type of information is still missing. In other words, the decisive question is not *Where should I buy this product?* but *Do I already know enough to buy it?* This interpretation slightly shifts the emphasis of the omnichannel literature reviewed in Chapter 2. Previous research identifies residual uncertainty as the main driver of webrooming behavior (Flavián et al., 2016, p. 460; Peck & Childers, 2003, p. 35). The present findings support this assumption but also suggest that uncertainty should not be treated as a single construct. Instead, consumers distinguish between different forms of uncertainty, each requiring different sources of information. Across both focus groups, cognitive uncertainty was frequently resolved within the digital environment. Livestreams enabled participants to compare products, observe demonstrations, ask questions in real time, and evaluate recommendations from both the host and other viewers. These elements often provided sufficient information about product functionality, value, or suitability. Sensory uncertainty, however, followed a different pattern. Questions regarding fabric quality, fit, texture, or physical comfort typically remained unresolved after the livestream, and in the two cases in which participants reported an actual store visit it was such a question that motivated it. Whether residual sensory uncertainty motivates a store visit more generally cannot be established from this dataset. Importantly, this did not occur because the livestream had failed. Rather, participants often described the stream as having answered almost every relevant question except the one requiring physical interaction with the product. In the reported store-visit cases, both of which concerned relatively high-investment products, participants described entering the store with a narrowly defined sensory question rather than engaging in broad exploratory shopping. The livestream had already completed the cognitive evaluation phase, leaving only those aspects requiring physical interaction. In such cases, the store visit did not represent a search for alternatives but a targeted verification of one remaining attribute.

Consequently, the findings suggest that LSS does not generally encourage offline shopping. Instead, it appears to encourage offline continuation mainly where it resolves the information that can realistically be communicated digitally while leaving an identifiable sensory question unanswered. In this sense, a livestream that succeeds on its own terms may make a store visit more rather than less plausible, because it narrows the consumer's remaining uncertainty to aspects that can only be evaluated physically. Given the small number of reported transitions, this is put forward as an interpretation to be tested rather than as an established effect.

6.2 Trust as a Facilitating Mechanism, Not Only an Outcome

A second interpretation concerns the role of trust throughout the customer journey. The literature reviewed in Chapter 2 consistently identifies trust as an important outcome of livestream shopping, particularly through repeated interaction with the livestream host and the development of parasocial relationships. The pattern of host transparency reported in Section 5.2 suggests something additional about how that trust is formed. Participants interpreted the acknowledgment of what the format could not convey in a consistent way across otherwise dissimilar product categories, which suggests that trust may be generated less through continuous positive persuasion than through selective transparency. In other words, consumers seem to interpret the acknowledgment of limitations as evidence that recommendations made elsewhere in the livestream can be considered more reliable. Such an interpretation also helps explain why several participants simultaneously trusted the host while remaining aware of the commercial nature of the relationship. Some explicitly questioned whether such trust was fully appropriate given the promotional context, while others described consciously verifying recommendations independently before purchase. These accounts indicate that parasocial trust does not necessarily require consumers to suspend critical thinking. Instead, participants appeared capable of maintaining a reflective attitude while nevertheless considering the host to be a credible source of information. The findings therefore suggest that trust should not be understood only as an endpoint of the livestream experience. It is certainly an outcome of repeated exposure and interaction, as the literature reviewed in Chapter 2 argues. In addition, however, participants' accounts indicate that it also operates as a facilitating mechanism, reducing perceived uncertainty at later stages of the journey. Understood in this way, trust functions not only as an emotional attachment but also as a resource that allows consumers to move towards a purchase decision with greater confidence.

6.3 Understanding the Measurement Gap

A third interpretation relates to the manager interview and the practical difficulties associated with measuring omnichannel behavior. Initially, the inability to connect livestream viewers with subsequent in-store purchases was described primarily as an operational limitation. However, when considered together with the consumer data, this issue may reflect a more fundamental characteristic of omnichannel shopping behavior. Participants rarely described a direct and immediate transition from livestream to store. Instead, offline visits were often embedded within everyday routines and combined with existing plans rather than undertaken as dedicated shopping trips. In several cases, visits were postponed until after additional online research and personal reflection. These accounts illustrate that the influence of LSS is often indirect and unfolds over time. Rather than producing a clearly identifiable conversion event, livestreams appear to shape later decisions that may ultimately result in a physical store visit under favorable circumstances. From this perspective, the measurement problem identified by the manager may not simply reflect insufficient technological infrastructure. Instead, it may arise because the underlying consumer behavior itself is difficult to attribute to a single touchpoint. The influence of LSS develops gradually across multiple interactions and therefore resists traditional attribution models that seek to assign purchases to one identifiable channel. This interpretation complements the omnichannel literature discussed in Chapter 2. Whereas previous studies primarily highlight methodological challenges in measuring cross-channel effects, the present findings raise the possibility that part of the difficulty lies in the structure of the behavior itself. This is offered as a tentative explanation only. It rests on a single manager interview and on self-reported consumer accounts, and distinguishing a genuinely diffuse customer journey from a straightforward absence of tracking infrastructure would require data that this study does not have.

6.4 Toward a Conditional Activation Model of LSS

Bringing these interpretations together, the findings suggest that LSS should not primarily be understood as a digital sales channel. Instead, it appears to function as a conditional activation mechanism within the broader omnichannel customer journey. The data indicate that whether a livestream ultimately encourages a physical store visit depends on the interaction of several conditions rather than on a single factor. Figure 2 summarizes these conditions and the pathways associated with them. The framework is exploratory. It was developed inductively from a small qualitative dataset in which only two participants reported an actual transition from livestream to store, and it is therefore best read as a structured set of interacting conditions that plausibly shape whether offline continuation occurs, rather than as a validated sequence of decision steps through which consumers pass in a fixed order. The conditions are presented in an order that reflects the logic of the argument rather than a temporal sequence, and the pathways shown are those observed in this dataset; further pathways are likely to exist.

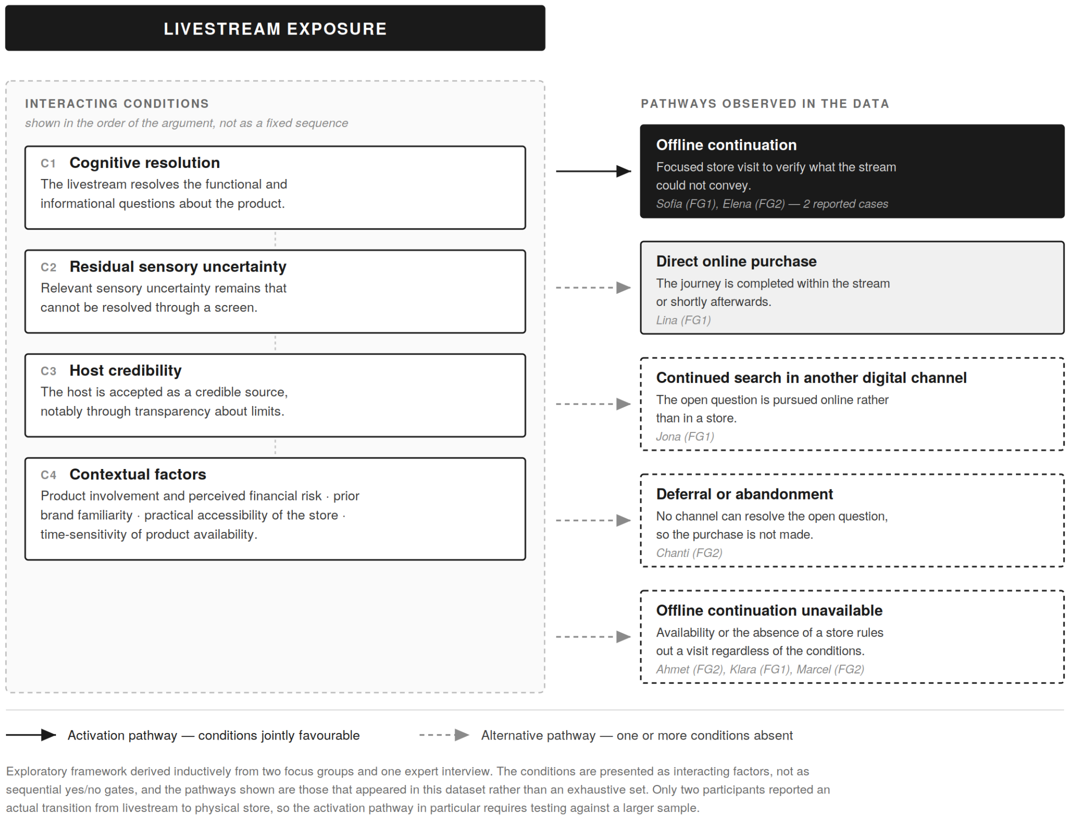

Figure 2: Conditional Activation Model of live streaming shopping (exploratory framework). Source: Own illustration

First, the livestream substantially reduces cognitive uncertainty by providing detailed product information, demonstrations, and opportunities for interaction. Where this does not happen, the accounts collected here point to more than one possible outcome. The purchase may be deferred or abandoned, as in Chanti's case, but the consumer may equally continue the information search in another digital channel, as Jona described. Second, some degree of sensory uncertainty remains unresolved after the stream. If all relevant information can be obtained digitally, consumers often purchase directly online. Conversely, if the remaining uncertainty concerns sensory product attributes that require physical evaluation, consumers may be more likely to continue their journey offline. Third, the perceived credibility of the livestream host appears to influence whether consumers accept the information provided during the stream as sufficient to narrow their remaining uncertainty. Trust therefore facilitates the transition from information search to purchase consideration rather than directly causing store visits. Finally, a set of contextual factors shapes this process. Product category, perceived financial risk, previous experience with the brand, the practical accessibility of physical stores, and the time-sensitivity of product availability all appear to influence whether consumers continue their journey offline or complete it within the digital environment. These are described here as contextual factors, or boundary conditions, rather than as moderators, since the qualitative design does not permit a test of moderation: they are conditions that were present or absent in participants' accounts, not variables whose effect has been estimated. They also appear to operate flexibly rather than as strict prerequisites, in that Elena's high-involvement purchase outweighed a considerable travel distance. Taken together, the framework assigns distinct roles to the three mechanisms addressed in RQ2: residual sensory uncertainty operates as a condition, host credibility as a facilitator, and brand familiarity as one of several contextual factors. Taken together, these findings lead to an interpretation that extends the conceptual framework developed in Chapter 2. Rather than proposing that livestream shopping generally complements or substitutes for physical retail, this study suggests that both outcomes are possible, and that its design allows the conditions associated with each to be described rather than their relative frequency to be established. Whether complementarity occurs depends on whether LSS successfully resolves those uncertainties that can be addressed digitally while simultaneously motivating consumers to seek the remaining sensory information in the physical store. This interpretation positions LSS not as an isolated sales format but as one touchpoint within a broader omnichannel customer journey whose strategic value lies in guiding consumers towards the channel that is best suited to resolving their remaining decision uncertainty.

Table 1 links each condition to the corresponding accounts from the focus groups and the expert interview.

Table 1: Conditions of the Conditional Activation Model and supporting empirical evidence

Condition	Description	Supporting evidence
C1 **Cognitive Resolution**	The livestream resolves the functional and informational questions surrounding the product, through demonstration, real-time interaction, and peer input.	Focus groups: Elena (FG2) described the stream as having completed the consideration phase before the store visit; Klara (FG1) and Marcel (FG2) reported that the live Q&A element resolved their remaining question during the stream itself. Expert interview: Manager A reported that the host's personal usage information provided guidance that was difficult to communicate through standard product pages, and that products presented in detail generated fewer returns (Section 4.2.2).
C2 **Residual Sensory Uncertainty**	Relevant sensory uncertainty remains that cannot be resolved through a screen. In the reported cases this narrowed the decision to a small number of physically verifiable attributes, although the data do not establish that a single attribute is required.	Focus groups: Elena (FG2) identified cushion firmness as the single open question; fashion participants across both groups referred to fabric feel, fit, and sizing; Jona (FG1) noted that sound quality could not be conveyed. His account supports the presence of residual sensory uncertainty but not the store-visit pathway, since he did not regard a store visit as capable of resolving it and turned to another digital channel instead. Expert interview: Manager A distinguished higher-consideration categories such as outerwear from basic items, associating the former with continued offline journeys (Section 4.1.2).
C3 **Host Credibility**	The host is perceived as a credible source, established notably through transparent acknowledgment of what the format cannot convey.	Focus groups: Sofia (FG1) reported increased trust after the presenter disclosed that a garment's color might differ under other lighting; Elena (FG2) cited the host's admission about cushion firmness as a reason she considered her trustworthy; Klara (FG1) described trust migrating from host to brand over repeated exposure (Section 4.2.1). Expert interview: Manager A described customers accepting the host's sizing guidance because it was framed through her own use of the product (Section 4.2.2). Counter-instances: Michael (FG1) and Marcel (FG2) maintained deliberate critical distance while still treating the host as informative, indicating that credibility does not require uncritical acceptance (Section 4.2.1).
C4 **Contextual Moderators**	Product involvement, perceived financial risk, prior brand familiarity, practical store accessibility, and the time-sensitivity of availability jointly	Focus groups: Sofia (FG1) embedded the store visit in plans she already had rather than making a dedicated trip, and referred to in-stream nearby-store information; Elena (FG2) traveled approximately two hours for a high-

	shape whether offline continuation is realistic.	investment purchase; Lina (FG1) explained that established familiarity with a brand's sizing removed the need for further verification; Ahmet (FG2) noted that limited sneaker releases sell out before a store visit is feasible (Sections 4.1.1, 4.2.1, 4.3.1). Expert interview: Manager A reported that established customers required fewer intermediate steps than first-time customers (Section 4.2.2).
Boundary conditions identified in the data		
C1 met, **C2 absent**	All relevant information is obtainable digitally; no sensory question remains to be resolved in a store.	Lina (FG1) explained that established familiarity with a brand's sizing left no open question requiring verification in another channel; the purchase was completed without further information search (Sections 4.2.1).
C2 present, **not resolvable**	A sensory or experiential question remains that no channel can answer, leading to discontinuation rather than channel switching.	Chanti (FG2) abandoned a kitchen product purchase because long-term durability could not be assessed either during the stream or in a store.
C1 not met, resolution sought elsewhere	The livestream does not resolve the functional questions, and the consumer completes the information search in another digital channel rather than offline or by discontinuing.	Jona (FG1) described the livestream as providing little substance on the attribute that mattered to him and resolved the remaining question through independent online reviews, noting that no store visit would have helped either (Section 4.1.1).
C4 **unfavorable**	Conditions C1 to C3 are met, but situational constraints make an offline visit impractical.	Ahmet (FG2) described limited sneaker releases selling out before a store visit would be possible, making online purchase the only realistic route; this was accepted as a characteristic of the category rather than a retailer failure (Sections 4.1.1, 4.3.1).
No offline **channel available**	The brand operates direct-to-consumer only; offline continuation is structurally unavailable rather than contextually unattractive.	Klara (FG1) and Marcel (FG2) purchased from brands without a physical retail presence, so no store visit was possible irrespective of residual uncertainty (Section 4.3.1).

Note. FG1 and FG2 denote the first and second consumer focus group. Section references indicate where the underlying accounts are reported in Chapter 4. The conditions are presented as interacting factors identified in an exploratory qualitative dataset, not as a validated causal sequence. Source: Own compilation based on the focus group and expert interview data.

7 Recommendations

The findings of this study indicate that the effectiveness of live streaming shopping depends on several interacting conditions. Rather than assuming that LSS automatically generates online sales or increases store traffic, retailers should recognize that its value varies across product categories, customer needs, and shopping situations. The recommendations presented below translate the empirical findings into practical implications for retailers that already use LSS or are considering implementing it as part of their omnichannel strategy. Given the exploratory design, the small sample and the fact that only two participants reported an actual transition from a livestream to a physical store, these recommendations are offered as directions worth testing in practice rather than as evidence-based prescriptions.

7.1 Differentiate Livestream Strategies by Product Category

One of the central implications of this study is that retailers should avoid applying the same livestream strategy across all product categories. Instead, livestream objectives should reflect the type of product being presented and the role the physical store is expected to play within the customer journey.

The findings suggest that products involving little residual uncertainty, such as basic apparel or frequently purchased items, are well suited to immediate in-stream conversion. In these cases, consumers generally obtain enough information during the livestream to complete the purchase online.

For products characterized by greater sensory uncertainty, however, a different objective appears more appropriate. Categories such as outerwear, knitwear or furniture often require consumers to physically evaluate attributes such as fit, texture or comfort before committing to a purchase. Rather than encouraging immediate online conversion, retailers should therefore use livestreams to increase consumers' confidence and deliberately encourage a subsequent store visit.

Both the consumer focus groups and the manager interview support this distinction, suggesting that category-specific livestream objectives are likely to create greater value than applying identical performance targets across all products.

7.2 Encourage Focused Store Visits by Addressing Remaining Uncertainty

In the reported store-visit cases, consumers entered the store with a clearly defined remaining question rather than a general sense of uncertainty. This suggests that livestreams may be better placed to support a store visit when they leave viewers with a specific open question rather than with diffuse doubt.

Retailers should therefore encourage hosts to openly acknowledge those product characteristics that cannot be fully communicated through a livestream. For example, hosts might explain that fabric texture, garment weight or sofa firmness can only be properly experienced in person while emphasizing that all other relevant information has already been covered during the stream. Rather than weakening consumers' confidence, this transparency appeared to strengthen host credibility while simultaneously giving consumers a clear reason to continue their journey offline. Retailers could further support this process by integrating practical store-related information directly into the livestream, such as nearby store locations, product availability or store reservation options. Such features reduce the effort required for consumers to continue their journey and make the transition between channels more seamless.

7.3 Build Host Credibility Through Authentic Communication

The results suggest that host credibility should not be viewed as an individual personality trait but as an organizational capability that can be deliberately developed. Across both focus groups, participants consistently described greater trust when hosts openly discussed product limitations or acknowledged situations in which a physical store could provide additional information. Purchase intention was not measured in this study. What the accounts indicate is that this type of communication did not appear to reduce the host's credibility and was, in participants' descriptions, associated with stronger perceptions of authenticity. Retailers should therefore expand host training beyond presentation skills and product knowledge. Training programs should also encourage transparent communication, realistic product demonstrations and appropriate acknowledgment of situations in which livestreams cannot fully replace physical product experience.

Developing these communication skills across multiple hosts may also reduce organizational dependence on a single highly trusted presenter, a risk that was explicitly highlighted during the manager interview.

7.4 Improve Cross-Channel Measurement While Recognizing Its Limits

A recurring finding of this study is that retailers currently have only limited visibility into how livestreams influence subsequent offline purchasing behavior. Although complete attribution may remain difficult because customer journeys often unfold over several days and across multiple touchpoints, retailers can still improve their understanding of cross-channel behavior through incremental measurement approaches. Examples include linking livestream participation to loyalty programs, offering livestream-specific store vouchers, or allowing customers to reserve featured products for in-store collection. While these approaches cannot capture every customer journey, they can provide valuable directional insights into the offline effects of livestream shopping. In addition, retailers should formalize qualitative feedback from store employees. Store managers reported customers referring to "the video" or arriving with screenshots of livestream content (see Section 4.3.2). Recording these observations systematically could provide directional evidence of cross-channel influence that is currently lost.

7.5 Strengthen Coordination Between Livestream and Store Teams

The transition from livestream to physical store depends not only on consumer behavior but also on organizational coordination. In the accounts reported here, the cross-channel experiences that participants described positively were those in which store employees were aware of ongoing livestream activities and recognized the products customers referred to. Conversely, a lack of internal communication may create the impression that online and offline channels operate independently, thereby weakening the omnichannel experience. Retailers should therefore establish simple but consistent communication processes between livestream teams and physical stores. Major livestream events should be accompanied by short staff briefings summarizing featured products, key campaign messages and expected customer enquiries. Even a centralized internal overview of recently featured products could help store employees respond more confidently when customers mention a livestream.

7.6 Align Internal Performance Metrics Across Channels

Finally, the case examined here suggests that an important barrier to effective omnichannel retailing may be organizational rather than technological. As this rests on a single managerial interview, it is presented as an issue identified in this organization rather than as a general finding. The manager interview revealed that livestream success is primarily evaluated using online performance indicators such as livestream conversion rates and digital sales. At the same time, physical stores are evaluated according to store traffic and offline revenue. As long as these objectives remain separate, different departments are likely to optimize their own performance rather than the overall customer journey. Retailers should therefore introduce shared performance indicators that capture both online and offline outcomes. Instead of evaluating livestreams solely on immediate online sales, success measures could include total sales of featured products across all channels, increases in store visits following livestream campaigns, or combined customer lifetime value. Aligning incentives across departments would encourage livestream teams and store managers to pursue common objectives and would better reflect the omnichannel role that LSS appears to play according to the findings of this study.

7.7 Overall Recommendation

Taken together, the recommendations presented in this chapter point towards one overarching principle. Live streaming shopping should not primarily be managed as an isolated online sales channel. Instead, retailers should view it as one touchpoint within a broader omnichannel customer journey. Rather than maximizing immediate online conversion alone, successful livestream strategies should help consumers obtain the information they need at each stage of the decision-making process while guiding them towards the channel best suited to resolving any remaining uncertainty. For some products this may result in an online purchase, whereas for others the main value of LSS may lie in encouraging a confident and well-informed visit to a physical store. This perspective shifts the strategic objective of LSS from maximizing channel-specific performance to supporting the overall customer journey and creating value across channels.

8 Limitations

Every research project is subject to limitations that need to be considered when interpreting its findings. The aim of this study was to explore the relationship between live streaming shopping and offline consumer behavior from an interpretivist perspective. Consequently, the findings provide in-depth insights into participants' experiences and perceptions rather than statistically generalizable conclusions.

8.1 Sample Size and Composition

The study draws on two consumer focus groups with a total of nine participants and one semi-structured expert interview. Participants were recruited through convenience sampling within the researcher's personal and professional networks. While this approach is appropriate for exploratory qualitative research, it inevitably limits the diversity of perspectives represented in the dataset. Although participants differed in their shopping habits and experiences with LSS, they cannot be regarded as representative of the wider consumer population. Most participants were already familiar with digital shopping environments and willing to discuss their experiences in a group setting. Consumers with little experience of LSS or lower levels of digital engagement may perceive the technology differently. Consequently, the findings should be understood as context-specific insights rather than broadly generalizable patterns. While the sample was deliberately varied in usage intensity and channel preference, this does not remove the limitations of convenience sampling as such. A further aspect of the sample is particularly consequential for this study and concerns the number of relevant cases rather than the number of participants. Although all nine focus group participants had prior exposure to live streaming shopping, only two of them, Sofia and Elena, reported an actual transition from a livestream to a physical store. The remaining accounts describe why such a transition did not take place, which is analytically valuable and informs the boundary conditions set out in Section 6.4, but it means that the activation pathway at the centre of RQ1 rests on a very narrow empirical base. The Conditional Activation Model presented in Section 6.4 should be read with this in mind. It is an exploratory framework derived from a small number of cases and requires testing against a larger and more varied sample before any claim regarding its general applicability can be made.

8.2 Limited Managerial Perspective

A second limitation concerns the managerial perspective. The original research design envisaged several expert interviews across different retailers in order to compare organizational approaches to live streaming shopping. Due to practical constraints, only one interview could ultimately be conducted. Although the interview generated rich and highly relevant data, it reflects the practices and experiences of a single organization operating within the fashion industry. Other retailers may differ substantially in their level of digital maturity, organizational structure, or strategic priorities. The findings relating to organizational decision-making and channel management should therefore be interpreted as illustrative rather than representative.

8.3 Reliance on Self-Reported Data

The study is based entirely on participants' retrospective accounts of their own experiences. Such data are inherently subject to limitations including recall bias, selective memory, and post-hoc rationalization. Participants may unintentionally reconstruct their decision-making processes in a more coherent way than they actually unfolded during the shopping journey. Similarly, the manager's observations regarding customer behavior and organizational outcomes were based largely on professional experience rather than systematically collected behavioral evidence. Consequently, the study captures participants' interpretations of reality rather than objectively observable behavior.

8.4 Absence of Behavioral Data

A further limitation concerns the absence of behavioral or transactional data. No purchase records, livestream analytics, loyalty program data, or store visit information were available to validate participants' accounts. As a result, the conditional activation model (see Figure 2) proposed in this thesis is derived from qualitative interpretations rather than directly observed consumer behavior. While this does not reduce the value of the insights generated, it means that the proposed relationships should be understood as theoretically informed explanations that require further empirical testing.

8.5 Contextual Scope

The study focuses primarily on product categories characterized by relatively high levels of consumer involvement, including fashion, furniture, skincare, electronics, footwear, and household products. Other categories, such as groceries, luxury goods, or services, may involve different decision-making processes and therefore different relationships between LSS and physical retail. In addition, all participants were located within a European context. Given that live streaming shopping has developed differently across international markets, particularly when compared with China, the findings should not automatically be transferred to other cultural settings without further investigation.

8.6 Language of Transcripts

All data were collected and transcribed in German, while the analysis is reported in English. Quotations presented in Chapter 4 are therefore translations rather than participants' original words. Translation was carried out by the researcher with a focus on conveying meaning rather than literal wording, which necessarily involves interpretive choices, particularly where participants used colloquial expressions or hedging language. Nuances of emphasis and register may consequently be attenuated in the reported quotations. Coding was performed on the German transcripts in order to keep the analysis close to the original data, and translation was undertaken only at the reporting stage.

8.7 Researcher Interpretation

Finally, the interpretivist approach adopted in this study acknowledges that qualitative analysis inevitably involves researcher interpretation. Although the coding process followed the systematic procedures proposed by Braun and Clarke (2006), decisions regarding theme development, interpretation, and theoretical integration remained dependent on the researcher's judgement. To enhance transparency, the analysis combined deductive concepts derived from the literature with inductive coding and explicitly considered cases that did not support the dominant patterns. Nevertheless, alternative interpretations of the same dataset would remain possible. Rather than representing a weakness, this reflects the interpretive nature of qualitative research and the objective of generating rich contextual understanding instead of identifying universal causal relationships.

9 Conclusion

This thesis set out to investigate whether live streaming shopping can influence consumer behavior beyond the digital environment by encouraging visits to physical retail stores. While existing research has largely examined LSS as an online sales channel, comparatively little attention has been paid to its role within the wider omnichannel customer journey. Addressing this gap formed the central objective of the study.

Drawing on two consumer focus groups and one semi-structured expert interview, the study explored three research questions concerning the conditions under which LSS encourages a physical store visit, the mechanisms that drive this behavior, and the circumstances under which LSS complements rather than substitutes for offline retail. The findings suggest that a store visit following a livestream is neither automatic nor solely determined by the channel itself. Instead, participants consistently described their decisions in terms of whether they possessed sufficient information to make a confident purchase. Participants described live streaming shopping as particularly useful for reducing cognitive uncertainty, through product demonstrations, opportunities for interaction, and access to first-hand product information. Where sensory questions remained unresolved, particularly for products requiring physical evaluation, a store visit was one of several possible responses alongside further online research, acceptance of the remaining risk, and abandonment of the purchase. In the two cases in which such a visit occurred, participants described it as the continuation of an ongoing decision process rather than as a fresh start. Rather than representing a failure of the digital channel, the store visit often reflected the success of the livestream in narrowing the decision to one final unresolved aspect.

The study also identified trust as a central mechanism underlying this process. Across both focus groups, participants consistently associated trust not simply with repeated exposure to a livestream host but with the host's willingness to acknowledge the limitations of the livestream format itself. By openly communicating what could not be demonstrated through a screen, hosts appeared to strengthen their credibility and, in turn, consumers' confidence in both the product and the brand.

Building on these findings, the thesis proposes an exploratory Conditional Activation Model of live streaming shopping (see Figure 2). Rather than viewing LSS primarily as an online sales channel, the model conceptualizes it as an omnichannel touchpoint whose influence depends on several interacting conditions. The framework suggests that store visits may occur when livestreams resolve cognitive uncertainty while leaving meaningful sensory uncertainty, when purchase involvement is high enough to justify further effort, and when the host has established credibility through transparent communication. Where these conditions were absent, participants described purchasing directly online, continuing the search in another digital channel, or discontinuing the purchase process altogether. Because the framework is derived from a small qualitative sample, it is offered as a basis for further research rather than as a validated model.

From a theoretical perspective, the study connects research on omnichannel retailing, ROPO and webrooming behavior, and parasocial interaction, and its contribution lies in specifying the conditions under which these mechanisms interact in the case of LSS. Rather than treating online and offline channels as competing alternatives, the findings illustrate how digital and physical touchpoints may complement one another, while also pointing to clear boundary conditions under which they do not.

Practically, the study suggests that retailers should differentiate livestream objectives according to customer information needs rather than applying uniform conversion targets, treat host credibility as an organizational capability rather than an individual trait, improve coordination between digital and store teams, and approach cross-channel measurement as a directional rather than an exact exercise.

Naturally, the findings should be interpreted in light of the study's qualitative design, limited sample, and single managerial perspective. Future research could build on the proposed conditional activation model by examining its applicability across different industries, cultural contexts, and larger consumer samples. Combining qualitative insights with behavioral or transactional data would also provide valuable opportunities to further validate the mechanisms identified in this study. Overall, this thesis suggests that the strategic value of live streaming shopping extends beyond immediate online sales. When integrated effectively into an omnichannel retail strategy, LSS has the potential to act as a catalyst that guides consumers from digital interaction to physical retail. Understanding how, when, and why this transition occurs represents an important step towards a more comprehensive understanding of the modern omnichannel customer journey.

10 List of Abbreviations

AR	Augmented Reality
BOPS	Buy Online, Pick Up in Store
C1-C4	Conditions 1 to 4 of the Conditional Activation Model
FG1	Focus Group 1
FG2	Focus Group 2
GDPR	General Data Protection Regulation
KPI	Key Performance Indicator
LSS	Live Streaming Shopping
ROPO	Research Online, Purchase Offline
RQ1-RQ3	Research Questions 1 to 3
S-O-R	Stimulus-Organism-Response
USD	United States Dollar

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13 Bibliography

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Appendix Overview

1 Appendix A: Focus Group Discussion Guide

The following discussion guide was used to moderate both consumer focus groups. Questions served as thematic prompts rather than a rigid script; the moderator adapted phrasing and follow-up probes to the natural flow of the conversation, consistent with the exploratory, experience-centered approach described in Chapter 3.

Section 1: Shopping Behavior and Experience with LSS

Objective: Establish participants' general shopping habits, channel preferences, and prior experience with live streaming shopping.

1. Could you describe your general shopping habits? Where do you typically shop, what categories, and how do you decide between online and in-store?

2. What experience do you have with live streaming shopping specifically watching brands or hosts present products in a live format?

3. Could you describe one specific livestream that you remember well? What made it memorable?

Section 2: Experience During the Livestream

Objective: Explore the in-stream experience, including informational value, emotional engagement, and absorption.

4. What kept you watching? What makes the difference between scrolling past and actually staying?

5. Compared to a standard online product page, what additional information did the livestream provide?

6. How did you experience the stream emotionally not just informationally, but how did it feel to watch?

7. Did you ever become so absorbed in a stream that you lost track of time?

Section 3: Perception of the Host, Trust, and Brand Familiarity

Objective: Examine the role of the host in shaping product evaluation, trust formation, and brand perception.

8. How important is the host in shaping how you evaluate the products presented?

9. What specifically builds or breaks your trust in a host?

10. Have you reached a point where you felt you actually knew the host a sense of familiarity or personal connection?

11. Has watching livestreams changed how you perceive the brands themselves not just the host, but the brand behind them?

12. When you purchased something after a livestream, would you say you trusted the host, the brand, or both?

Section 4: Product Evaluation and Remaining Uncertainty

Objective: Identify what product information participants could and could not obtain through the livestream, and how they dealt with remaining uncertainty.

13. Think of a specific product you were interested in during a livestream. What could you evaluate well through the format?

14. What remained uncertain or unclear after watching?

15. How did you deal with those remaining uncertainties?

16. Looking back, did the livestream give you enough information to make a confident purchase decision?

Section 5: From the Livestream to the Physical Store

Objective: Explore whether and how the livestream led to a physical store visit, including the decision-making process and triggers.

17. Has anyone visited a physical store after watching a livestream? If so, could you walk us through what happened from the stream to the store?

Probe: *Was the visit planned specifically because of the stream, or more spontaneous?*

18. For those who have not visited a store: What would it take for a livestream to send you to a store?

19. Are there product categories where you would always want to physically check before buying, regardless of how good the stream was?

Section 6: Connection Between Online and Offline Channels

Objective: Assess participants' perceptions of channel integration, consistency, and the overall coherence of the cross-channel experience.

20. For those who visited a store: Did the livestream experience influence how you behaved in the store?

21. Did the in-store experience match what you had seen in the stream?

22. Overall, how connected did the online stream and the in-store experience feel?

Section 7: Reflection and Future Outlook

Objective: Invite participants to reflect on the broader relationship between LSS and physical retail, and to identify areas for improvement.

23. In which situations do you think a livestream can completely replace a store visit?

24. In which situations would you always prefer a physical store, regardless of the stream quality?

25. If you could improve livestream shopping to make it work better for you, what would you change?

26. Is there anything about your experience with livestream shopping and physical stores that we have not covered?

2 Appendix B: Semi-Structured Expert Interview Guide

The following guide structured the semi-structured interview with a Brand & Digital Retail Manager. Consistent with the semi-structured format, the interviewer adapted the sequence and depth of questions based on the interviewee's responses.

Section 1: Company Background and Role

1. Could you briefly describe your role within the company and your main responsibilities?

2. What role does live streaming shopping currently play within your overall retail strategy?

3. How has that role evolved since you first adopted the format?

Section 2: Strategic Objectives of Live Streaming Shopping

4. When you run a livestream today, what are you trying to achieve?

5. How do you define a successful stream in practice?

6. Are there product categories that work particularly well or poorly in the format?

Section 3: Consumer Behavior and Decision-Making

7. From your perspective, how do customers typically behave during and after a livestream?

8. Have you noticed differences between customers who purchase immediately and those who continue their journey through other channels?

9. What role does trust in the host and in the brand play in customers' purchase decisions during livestreams?

Section 4: The Customer Journey and Physical Stores

10. Where do you see livestream shopping within the broader customer journey at which stage?

11. Do you observe or believe that livestreams encourage customers to visit physical stores?

12. Which products are most likely to send customers into stores after watching a stream?

13. What information gaps do customers still arrive at stores with after watching a livestream?

Section 5: Integration of Online and Offline Channels

14. How are your livestream activities coordinated with the physical stores in practice?

15. What happens when coordination works well, and what happens when it does not?

16. What are the biggest structural challenges in building a seamless cross-channel experience?

Section 6: Performance Measurement

17. Which KPIs do you currently use to evaluate livestream shopping?

18. How do you currently measure or attempt to measure the influence of streams on physical store performance?

19. If you could design your ideal measurement system, what would you most want to track?

Section 7: Future Outlook

20. How do you expect livestream shopping to evolve over the next five years?

21. What role do you see physical stores playing in that future?

22. Do you see a scenario where livestream shopping drives more footfall to stores rather than away from them?

23. Is there anything important for understanding this space that we have not discussed?

3 Appendix C: Participant Overview

All participants were assigned pseudonyms to ensure anonymity in accordance with GDPR requirements. Participants were recruited through convenience sampling and deliberately selected to vary in livestream usage intensity and channel preference, subject to a minimum of prior exposure to live streaming shopping and to shopping across both channels.

Table C1: Focus Group 1 Participants

Pseudonym	Age	Shopping Profile	LSS Experience	Primary Product Categories
Klara	27	Predominantly online	Regular; weekly skincare streams	Skincare, beauty
Jona	34	Online for electronics	Occasional; approx. monthly	Electronics, gadgets
Lina	23	Almost entirely online	Frequent; near-weekly fashion streams	Fashion
Michael	41	Prefers physical stores	Minimal; 2-3 streams total	Household, tools, furniture
Sofia	30	Omnichannel; mixed online/offline	Regular; fashion and home goods	Fashion, home goods

Duration: approximately 83 minutes.

Table C2: Focus Group 2 Participants

Pseudonym	Age	Shopping Profile	LSS Experience	Primary Product Categories
Elena	38	Research-intensive; prefers in-store for large items	Occasional; product-driven	Furniture, home goods
Ahmet	26	Almost entirely online	Frequent; sneaker drops and streetwear	Sneakers, streetwear

Chanti	45	Traditional; prefers physical stores	Very limited; curiosity-driven	Kitchenware, household
Marcel	29	Predominantly online	Regular; weekly grooming streams	Grooming, skincare

Duration: approximately 79 minutes.

Note: Focus Group 2 was originally planned with five participants. One participant was unable to attend due to a scheduling conflict on the day of the session. Despite the smaller group size, the discussion generated substantial thematic depth across all planned topic areas.

Table C3: Expert Interview Participant

Pseudonym	Role	Organization Type	Responsibilities
Manager A	Brand & Digital Retail Manager	Mid-sized European fashion retailer with physical stores and e-commerce	E-commerce platform, livestream shopping programs, coordination with store operations

Duration: approximately 62 minutes. Conducted via video call.

4 Appendix D: Coding Scheme

The following tables document the coding scheme applied in the thematic analysis described in Section 3.4. Coding followed a hybrid approach. Table D1 lists the deductive codes derived from the conceptual framework developed in Chapter 2. Table D2 lists the codes that emerged inductively from the data and were not anticipated by the literature reviewed. Table D3 shows how the individual codes were grouped into themes and how these themes relate to the three research questions.

The source column indicates in which focus group or in the expert interview a given code was applied. It records the range of the code across the dataset rather than the number of coded segments. Codes were applied to the German transcripts; the English designations used here were introduced at the reporting stage.

Table D1: Deductive codes derived from the conceptual framework

Code	Definition	Sources	Theme
Utilitarian value	Informational or functional benefit obtained from the stream: demonstration, comparison, real-time answers.	FG1: Klara, Lina, Sofia. FG2: Elena, Marcel, Chanti	Cognitive resolution
Hedonic value	Entertainment, enjoyment or atmosphere as a reason for watching.	FG1: Lina, Klara, Sofia. FG2: Ahmet	Stream absorption
Symbolic value	Identification with the host's style or with the viewing community.	FG1: Lina, Klara. FG2: Marcel, Ahmet	Trust and parasocial familiarity
Trust in the host	Confidence in the presenter as a reliable source of product information.	All FG1 and FG2 participants; Expert interview	Trust and parasocial familiarity
Trust in the brand	Confidence in the retailer or brand behind the stream.	FG1: Klara, Sofia, Lina. FG2: Elena, Marcel	Trust and parasocial familiarity
Parasocial familiarity	Sense of personally knowing the host through repeated exposure.	FG1: Klara, Lina. FG2: Marcel. Counter-cases: Michael, Ahmet	Trust and parasocial familiarity
Flow and absorption	Loss of time awareness or deep immersion while watching.	FG1: Klara, Sofia, Lina. FG2: Ahmet, Elena, Marcel	Stream absorption
Uncertainty reduction through demonstration	Product attributes made assessable through live demonstration or close-up.	FG1: Klara, Lina, Sofia. FG2: Elena, Chanti, Ahmet	Cognitive resolution
Residual product uncertainty	Attribute that remains unresolved after watching the stream.	All FG1 and FG2 participants	Residual uncertainty
Brand familiarity as buffer	Prior experience with a brand reducing the need for further information.	FG1: Lina, Klara. FG2: Ahmet; Expert interview	Contextual factors
Temporal scarcity	Countdowns, limited releases or time-limited offers as a feature of the format.	FG1: Sofia, Lina, Michael. FG2: Ahmet, Chanti	Urgency and credibility
Cross-channel synergy	Positive stream experience raising engagement with another channel.	FG1: Sofia. FG2: Elena, Marcel; Expert interview	Channel relationship
Perceived connectivity and consistency	Perceived coherence and ease of movement between stream and store.	FG1: Sofia, Lina, Michael. FG2: Elena, Chanti; Expert interview	Channel relationship
Webrooming and offline continuation	Online information gathering followed by a physical store visit.	FG1: Sofia. FG2: Elena; Expert interview	Store visit as continuation

Code	Definition	Sources	Theme
Substitution and cannibalization	Online purchase replacing a store visit, or channels competing for the same sale.	FG1: Klara. FG2: Ahmet, Marcel; Expert interview	Channel relationship

Table D2: Inductive codes emerging from the data

Code	Definition	Sources	Theme
Host transparency about format limitations	Host openly states what the stream cannot convey; received as a credibility signal.	FG1: Sofia, Klara. FG2: Elena, Marcel	Trust and parasocial familiarity
Critical distance despite trust	Trust in the host maintained alongside explicit awareness of the commercial context.	FG1: Michael, Sofia. FG2: Marcel	Trust and parasocial familiarity
Sensory versus cognitive uncertainty	Distinction between questions answerable digitally and questions requiring physical contact.	FG1: Sofia, Klara, Lina, Jona. FG2: Elena, Marcel, Chanti	Residual uncertainty
Digital resolution of residual uncertainty	Open question closed within the stream chat or through independent online sources.	FG1: Klara, Jona. FG2: Marcel	Residual uncertainty
Purchase abandonment	Decision not to buy because the open question could not be resolved in any channel.	FG1: Michael. FG2: Chanti	Residual uncertainty
Focused store visit	Store entered with one predefined question rather than for exploratory browsing.	FG1: Sofia. FG2: Elena; Expert interview	Store visit as continuation
Price threshold	Monetary level above which residual uncertainty is no longer accepted.	FG1: Michael. FG2: Elena, Chanti; Expert interview	Contextual factors
Practical accessibility of the store	Store visit organized around existing routines or requiring dedicated travel.	FG1: Sofia. FG2: Elena	Contextual factors
Time-sensitivity of availability	Product sells out before a store visit is feasible.	FG2: Ahmet	Contextual factors
Absence of an offline channel	Brand operates direct-to-consumer, so no store visit is structurally possible.	FG1: Klara. FG2: Marcel	Channel relationship
Return friction as offline driver	Effort associated with online returns cited as a reason to buy in store.	FG1: Sofia, Klara	Contextual factors

Code	Definition	Sources	Theme
Urgency as credibility risk	Constructed time pressure perceived as manipulative and attributed to the brand.	FG1: Michael, Sofia. FG2: Chanti, Ahmet	Urgency and credibility
Format overwhelm	Pace, chat volume or information density leading to disengagement.	FG1: Michael, Sofia. FG2: Chanti	Residual uncertainty
Store staff awareness of stream content	Store employees recognizing products or campaigns referenced by customers.	FG1: Sofia. FG2: Elena; Expert interview	Channel relationship
Category-differentiated stream objectives	Different conversion goals assigned to streams depending on product category.	Expert interview	Store visit as continuation
Measurement gap	Inability to attribute in-store outcomes to prior livestream exposure.	Expert interview	Channel relationship
Internal channel conflict	Divergent objectives between e-commerce and retail operations functions.	Expert interview	Channel relationship
Host dependency risk	Organizational vulnerability arising from reliance on a single credible host.	Expert interview	Trust and parasocial familiarity

Table D3: Themes, constituent codes and relation to the research questions

Theme	Constituent codes	Research question	Reported in
Cognitive resolution	Utilitarian value; uncertainty reduction through demonstration	RQ1	Section 4.1; Condition C1
Residual uncertainty	Residual product uncertainty; sensory versus cognitive uncertainty; digital resolution; purchase abandonment; format overwhelm	RQ1, RQ2	Sections 4.1, 4.2; Condition C2
Trust and parasocial familiarity	Trust in the host; trust in the brand; parasocial familiarity; symbolic value; host transparency; critical distance; host dependency risk	RQ2	Section 4.2; Condition C3
Contextual factors	Brand familiarity as buffer; price threshold; practical accessibility; time-sensitivity of availability; return friction	RQ1, RQ3	Sections 4.1, 4.2, 4.3; Condition C4

Theme	Constituent codes	Research question	Reported in
Store visit as continuation	Webrooming and offline continuation; focused store visit; category-differentiated objectives	RQ1, RQ3	Sections 4.1, 4.3
Channel relationship	Cross-channel synergy; perceived connectivity and consistency; substitution and cannibalization; absence of an offline channel; store staff awareness; measurement gap; internal channel conflict	RQ3	Section 4.3
Stream absorption	Hedonic value; flow and absorption	Not assigned	Reported separately; not carried into the model
Urgency and credibility	Temporal scarcity; urgency as credibility risk	Not assigned	Inductive counter-finding; see note

Note: FG1 and FG2 denote the first and second consumer focus group. Two themes are marked as not assigned to a research question. Stream absorption and urgency and credibility emerged from the data but do not bear directly on the transition from livestream to physical store and are therefore reported as supplementary findings rather than integrated into the Conditional Activation Model presented in Section 6.4. Divergent cases were retained as separate codes rather than subsumed under the dominant pattern, consistent with the analytical approach described in Section 3.4.

Declaration of Authorship

I hereby declare that this master's thesis, entitled *"Live Streaming Shopping as an Activation Mechanism in the Omnichannel Customer Journey: A Qualitative Study of Consumer and Retailer Perspectives"*, is my own original work and that I have not used any sources or aids other than those cited. All passages taken from published or unpublished works, whether verbatim or in substance, have been identified as such. This thesis has not been submitted, in whole or in part, to any other examination authority and has not been published previously.

Barcelona, 20.08.2026

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